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The Household Diary Study

Mail Use & Attitudes in FY 2024



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HOUSEHOLD DIARY STUDY (HDS) FY 2024

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Executive Summary

This report documents the findings of the United States Postal Service's Household Diary Study (HDS) for Fiscal Year (FY) 2024. The main objectives of the study are to:

- Measure the types and volumes of mail sent and received by U.S. households,
- Track trends in mail usage over time, and
- Compare mail usage by household demographic characteristics.

The report examines these trends in the context of changes and developments in the markets in which the U.S. Postal Service operates: correspondence, transactions, advertising, periodicals, and package deliveries.

Background

The Household Diary Study survey, conducted each year since 1987, collects information about households' use of mail and how usage changes over time. The HDS consists of two surveys of households. The first survey is a preliminary *recruitment survey* which gathers information about household demographics and methods the household uses to pay and receive bills and statements, household attitudes toward mail advertising, and other information related to their use of the mail. The second survey is a *mail diary* in which households report the volumes and types of mail they received and sent during a given week.

The FY 2024 report covers Government Fiscal Year 2024, which ran from October 1, 2023, to September 30, 2024, with comparisons to 2014 and 2019, as appropriate.

Overview

As seen in Table E.1, in 2024, U.S. households received an average of 644 pieces of mail from non-households. Households sent an average of 19 pieces to non-households and there was an average of 19 pieces of mail sent from one household to another. Overall, total mail received or sent by households equaled 682 pieces per household in 2024.

The total volume of household mail can be estimated by multiplying the pieces per household by the total of 132.2 million U.S, households in 2024. That calculation produces an estimate of total household mail in 2024 of 90.2 billion pieces, or 80% of the 112.5 billion pieces of mail delivered by the USPS. The remaining 20% consists of mail from non-households to non-households, primarily businesses and governments.

Table E.1: Mail Received and Sent by Households

Mail Flows	Pieces per Household	All Households (Billions)
Non-Household to Household	644.2	85.2
Household to Non-Household	18.8	2.5
Household to Household	18.9	2.5
Total Household Mail	682.0	90.2
Total USPS Mail	—	112.5
Household Mail Share	—	**80%**

Sources: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024, RPW Reports. Notes: Totals may not sum due to rounding. Total USPS Mail Received and Sent by All Households found in RPW.

Mail Markets

The Household Diary Study examines mail by the markets the U.S. Postal Service serves. This design at times cuts across mail classes to provide a foundation for understanding mail flows and the marketplace changes that affect them. Table E.2 shows household mail volumes by market for 2014, 2019, and 2024.

Of the 682 pieces of mail received and sent per household in 2024, 97 pieces were correspondence mail and 111 pieces were transactions mail. Most household mail was advertising mail with 410 pieces received per household in 2024. In addition, households received an average of 20 periodicals in 2024 and received or sent 52 packages.

Table E.2: Household Mail Volume Sent and Received by Mail Market Served
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Market	2014	2019	2024	Change 2014 – 2024	Change 2019 – 2024
Correspondence	135.1	117.5	97.2	-28%	-17%
Transactions	214.7	159.1	111.0	-48%	-30%
Advertising	673.5	587.8	409.9	-39%	-30%
Periodicals	43.3	32.4	19.9	-54%	-39%
Packages	28.3	37.7	51.8	83%	37%
Other	21.2	14.7	6.0	-72%	-59%
Total	**1074.7**	**921.8**	**682.0**	**-37%**	**-26%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Notes: Correspondence and packages exclude double-counted pieces reported as both sent and received by households. Advertising includes First-Class advertising-enclosed mail that is also included in another category but excluded from total to avoid double-counting. Other includes unclassified First-Class Mail, and CDs and DVD sent by First-Class Mail.

Total household mail has been in decline for nearly twenty years. As shown in Table E.2, mail per household fell 37% from 2014 to 2024 and 26% from 2019 to 2024. Most of this decline is due to the ongoing shift of mail to various electronic alternatives available online and through other technologies. In addition, the social and economic disruptions caused by the COVID-19 pandemic negatively impacted many mail categories, most substantially advertising mail.

Focusing on the past ten years, per household volumes of correspondence mail declined 28%, transactions mail declined 48%, advertising mail declined 39%, and periodicals mail declined 54%. Note that because the total number of U.S. households grew 10% over the past decade, the declines in total mail volumes were less than the declines measured on a per household basis.

The exception to this decline in mail volume was seen with packages which increased 83% from 2014 to 2024, and 37% from 2019 to 2024. The increase in package volumes is a result of the growth in online shopping and e-commerce over the past decade, along with the surge in online shopping during the pandemic.

However, except for the benefit that growing use of online shopping has had on USPS package volumes, technological changes have mostly harmed mail volumes. A related development is the greater decline in mail volumes among younger households, which are more likely to be comfortable with using technological alternatives to the mail. This effect is presented in Table E.3 which shows trends in correspondence mail received and sent by age of the household head.

Table E.3: Correspondence Mail Volumes by Age of Household Head

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Age of Household Head	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Received					
18 to 34	94.0	72.3	52.0	-45%	-28%
35 to 54	123.3	101.9	87.7	-29%	-14%
55 and Older	141.9	132.1	114.9	-19%	-13%
All households	**124.7**	**109.9**	**93.2**	**-25%**	**-15%**
Sent					
18 to 34	19.8	11.1	3.8	-81%	-66%
35 to 54	31.8	20.9	11.6	-64%	-45%
55 and Older	46.8	36.1	22.1	-53%	-39%
All households	**35.5**	**26.0**	**14.9**	**-58%**	**-43%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample.

Households headed by someone 18 to 34 years old received an average of 52 pieces of correspondence mail in 2024 while households headed by someone aged 55 or older received an average of 115 pieces. Moreover, younger households saw a greater decline in correspondence mail received, with their volume falling 45% from 2014 to 2024 compared with a 19% decline for the older households. Age differences in correspondence mail sent were even greater. The youngest households sent fewer than 4 pieces of correspondence mail in 2024, 81% less than in 2014.

More evidence of how technological developments are affecting the mail is found in Tables E.4 which shows that household bills payments and household bills and statements received have shifted from the mail to electronic alternatives. For example, in 2014, households paid 33% of their bills by mail; by 2024 that share had dropped to 13% with 85% of household bills paid electronically. Table E.4 also shows that the share of bills and statements received by mail fell from 77% in 2014 to 52% in 2024.

Table E.4: Shares of Household Bills Paid vs. Bills and Statements Received

Household Bills **Paid** by Method			
Shares	**2014**	**2019**	**2024**
By Mail	33%	23%	13%
Electronically	62%	73%	85%
In Person	4%	3%	2%
Household Bills and Statements **Received** by Method			
Shares	**2014**	**2019**	**2024**
By Mail	77%	65%	52%
Electronically only	23%	35%	48%

Source: HDS Recruitment Sample. Notes: the 2014 sample covers the period 2014q2 to 2014q4 due to lack of data in 2014q1. By Mail includes Bills and Statements that may also be received electronically.

Advertising mail accounted for 60% of all household mail in 2024. Although advertising mail has declined over the past decade, it continues to be an effective way of reaching both existing and prospective

customers. Table E.5 shows that 59% of advertising mail sent to existing customers is read by the recipients, and for 15% of this mail the recipient says they are considering responding to the mailing. Reading and response rates are lower for prospective customers – those that do not have a past relationship with the mailer – but they are still an indication that direct mail continues to be an effective way for businesses to expand their customer base.

Table E.5: Reading and Response Rates to Marketing Mail Advertising by Past Relationship
(Percentage of Pieces)

Past Business Relationship with Recipient	Reading Rate	Response Rate
Existing Customers	59%	15%
Prospects	26%	2%
All Recipients	**42%**	**8%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Note: Totals may not sum due to rounding. Response rate is percentage of pieces for which household is considering a response to the advertising.

Periodical mail volumes recorded in this report include only periodicals delivered by the USPS. Table E.6 shows that in 2024, households received an average of 20 periodicals, of which a little more than 12 were magazines, with newspapers being the second largest periodical category at about 6 pieces per household per year. Table E.6 also shows that magazines received have fallen 64% over the past ten years while newspapers received have fallen just 6%. However, the small decline in newspapers received is primarily because most of the decline in newspaper circulation occurred in the years before 2014.

Table E.6: Postal Service Periodical Type by Year
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Periodical Type	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014-2024	% change 2019-2024
Magazines	34.3	23.6	12.4	-64%	-48%
Newspapers	6.5	5.6	6.1	-6%	8%
Newsletters	1.7	2.4	1.1	-39%	-55%
Unclassified	0.8	0.8	0.4	-56%	-58%
Total Periodicals	**43.3**	**32.4**	**19.9**	**-54%**	**-39%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Totals may not sum due to rounding.

As discussed above, Table E.2 showed that packages are the only major postal market that has grown over the past decade. Table E.7 shows that most of this growth has occurred in more rural, less urbanized areas. Households living in one of the thirty largest Metropolitan Statistical Areas (MSAs) received 58% more packages in 2024 than in 2014 while households living in other MSAs received 95% more packages. While these increases are impressive, they pale in comparison to the 238% increase in the per household packages received by households living outside of MSAs. These data demonstrate that while the Postal Service has benefited from the general growth in the package market over the past decade, it is particularly well-positioned in less urbanized areas which are often underserved by USPS competitors.

Table E.7: Packages Received by MSA Classification

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Largest MSA	25.6	32.9	40.4	58%	23%
Other MSAs	26.2	37.6	51.1	95%	36%
Non-MSAs	19.4	40.4	65.6	238%	62%

Source: HDS Diary Sample.

Chapter 1: Introduction – Volumes & Trends

The United States Postal Service Household Diary Study (HDS) Report documents the findings of the Fiscal Year (FY) 2024 study. The HDS measures the mail sent and received by U.S. households, tracks volume trends over time, and compares mail usage by households' demographic characteristics.

The Survey

The Household Diary Study survey, conducted each year since 1987, collects information about U.S. household use of the mail and how usage changes over time. The types of information covered by the survey include:

- Volumes and types of mail sent and received,
- Demographics of mail users,
- Attitudes toward mail and advertising,
- Bill payment behavior.

The data generated by the recruitment survey and mail diary are the basis of the analysis in this report. The 2024 HDS report covers the 2024 government fiscal year which ran from October 1, 2023, through September 30, 2024. Data for 2014 and 2019 are also reported on a fiscal year basis.

The Survey Consists of Two Parts:

1) An **entry, or recruitment interview**, conducted by phone or Web, collects demographic and attitudinal information from about 9,800 households.
2) These households then receive a **mail diary**, which collects information on the mail the household sends and receives in a one-week period. Annually, about 5,500 households complete the diary.

Findings are used to assist in market research, forecasting, and strategic planning within the Postal Service and can be viewed by the public on the Postal Rate Commission website.

U.S. Postal Service Volumes

This section reviews all mail volumes processed by the Postal Service, as reported in RPW (Revenue, Piece, Weight) reports, and shown in Table 1.1. The data includes mail to and from households, as well as non-household to non-household mail. All other sections of the report will focus exclusively on household mail.

Mail Classes

- **First-Class Mail** is used to send transactional mail, correspondence, and advertising, and is limited to letters, cards and large envelopes weighing 13 ounces or less.
- **Marketing Mail** includes advertisements and marketing packages weighing less than 16 ounces. For the most part, Marketing Mail is comprised of letters, cards, and flats, although it contains a few postcards and packages as well. Marketing Mail is divided into Commercial and Nonprofit categories, the latter being mail sent by nonprofit agencies at reduced postage rates.
- **Periodicals** are magazines, newspapers, and newsletters, and are predominantly flat-shaped.

- **Package and Shipping Services** is used to deliver merchandise, books, catalogs, and media.
- **Competitive Mail** consists primarily of packages and parcels delivered by the Postal Service, which also face direct competition from other delivery companies.

As shown in Table 1.1, the Postal Service delivered 112.5 billion pieces of mail, in 2024, a decrease of 21% from 142.6 billion pieces delivered in 2019. The decrease was due largely to lower volumes of First-Class Mail and Marketing Mail, which fell 20% and 24%, respectively. From 2014 to 2024, total mail volume declined 28%. The decline in First-Class Mail was primarily due to the shift of correspondence and transactions mail to internet and other digital transmissions. First-Class Mail has been in decline for the past two decades and fell 31% from 2014 to 2024. In 2024, First-Class Mail represented about 40% of all mail delivered by the Postal Service.

Table 1.1: Total Mail Volume: FY 2014, 2019, and 2024

(Billions of Pieces)

Mail Classification	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Market Dominant Mail:					
First-Class Mail	**64.3**	**55.3**	**44.4**	**-31%**	**-20%**
Marketing Mail:					
Commercial	67.6	63.6	47.4	-30%	-26%
Nonprofit	12.8	12.1	10.2	-20%	-16%
Total Marketing Mail	**80.4**	**75.7**	**57.5**	**-28%**	**-24%**
Periodicals	**6.0**	**4.6**	**2.7**	**-55%**	**-41%**
USPS and Free Mail	0.5	0.3	0.4	-23%	17%
Package Services Mail	0.5	0.6	0.4	-22%	-31%
Total Market Dominant Mail	**151.7**	**136.5**	**105.5**	**-30%**	**-23%**
Total Competitive Mail	**3.8**	**6.0**	**6.9**	**83%**	**15%**
Total All Mail	**155.5**	**142.6**	**112.5**	**-28%**	**-21%**

Source: RPW Reports. Notes: Totals may not sum due to rounding. Revenue Pieces and Weight (RPW) Reports: used to track operational data and represent all mail processed by the USPS. They are distinct from the Household Diary Study.

The decline in Marketing Mail (consisting mostly of advertising materials) reflected a rapid increase in marketers' use of digital and mobile advertising, as well as declines related to the economic and social changes occurring during the 2020-2021 pandemic. Although Marketing Mail volume in 2024 was lower than in 2014 or 2019 there have been individual years in which Marketing Mail volume increased, most recently in 2021 and 2022. In 2024, Marketing Mail represented 51% of all mail delivered by the Postal Service.

Periodicals (primarily newspapers and magazines) have been in decline for more than two decades due to drops in circulation and the shift of publications and information to the internet. From 2019 to 2024, Periodicals Mail fell 41%, and in the most recent year accounted for 2.4% of all USPS mail.

In contrast to the other mail classes, Competitive Mail has increased due to the growth in online shopping and e-commerce activity. In 2024, Competitive Mail volume was 15% greater than in 2019 and 83% greater than in 2014. Competitive Mail represented 6% of total USPS volume in 2024 but because of its higher revenue per piece, it represented more than 40% of total USPS revenues.

Mail Flows: Sender and Recipient

Mail volume can be broken into four basic flows, based on the sender and the recipient. These flows are:

1) Household to household,
2) Household to non-household,
3) Non-household to household, and
4) Non-household to non-household, which is not measured by the Household Diary Study.

Table 1.2 presents volumes by type of mail flow as a percentage of the total. Most of the mail delivered by USPS is sent by non-households to households (76%), with just 20% of the mail sent between non-households (primarily businesses and governments). Only small fractions of mail volume are sent from one household to another household (2%) or from a household to a non-household (2%). Put another way, only about 4% of total USPS mail is sent by households.

Table 1.2: Total Domestic Mail Flows: 2024
(Percent of Total Mail Delivered by USPS)

Sent By:	Received By:	
	Household	Non-Household
Household	2%	2%
Non-Household	76%	20%

Source: HDS Survey, RPW Reports, FY 2024.

Table 1.3 presents these data in two other forms, pieces per household per year and total annual volume across all households in the U.S. Many of the subsequent results in this report are presented in terms of pieces per household per year.

In 2024, households received an average of 644 pieces from non-households. Households sent about 19 pieces to non-households during the year. Another 19 pieces were household-to-household mail.

The total volume sent to or received by households in 2024 is estimated by multiplying the 682 total pieces of mail per household by the 132.2 million U.S. households in 2024. Total household mail is estimated to be 90.2 billion pieces representing 80% of the 112.5 billion pieces of mail delivered by the USPS.

Table 1.3: Mail Received and Sent by Households in 2024

Mail Flows	Pieces per Household	All Households (Billions)
Non-Household to Household	644.2	85.2
Household to Non-Household	18.8	2.5
Household to Household	18.9	2.5
Total Household Mail	682.0	90.2
Total USPS Mail	—	112.5
Household Mail Share	—	**80%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Note: Totals may not sum due to rounding.

Table 1.4 below shows mail received and sent by households in 2014, 2019, and 2024 in terms of pieces per household per year.

Table 1.4: Mail Received and Sent by Households 2014, 2019, 2024
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Mail Flows	2014	2019	2024	% Change 2014-2024	% Change 2019-2024
Non-Household to Household	984.1	861.8	644.2	-35%	-25%
Household to Non-Household	57.8	35.3	18.8	-67%	-47%
Household to Household	32.7	24.7	18.9	-42%	-23%
Total Household Mail	1074.7	921.8	682.0	-37%	-26%
Total US Households (millions)	123.2	128.6	132.2	7%	3%

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Totals may not sum due to rounding.

Non-household-to-household mail declined 35% from 2014 to 2024, and 25% from 2019 to 2024. The most dramatic decrease in mail flows was observed in household-to-non-household mail, which declined by 67% from 2014 to 2024. A likely reason that this category fell more than others was the increased use of the internet and other technologies for paying bills and corresponding with businesses and governments. Household-to-household mail experienced a sizeable decrease with a 42% decline in the last decade. A major cause for this decline is the migration to online and electronic alternatives of correspondence by mail between households.

Overall, total household mail fell from 1,075 pieces per household in 2014 to 922 pieces per household in 2019 and to 682 pieces per household in 2024, a total decline of 37% over the past decade. Note that because the total number of U.S. households increased over the past ten years, the percentage decline in total household mail has been somewhat less than the percentage decline in pieces per household.

Mail Markets

While the USPS RPW report organizes mail by class, the HDS annual report organizes mail by the markets in which the Postal Service operates. In many cases, the mail markets and mail classes are identical. In some cases, the mail markets and classes differ. The markets analyzed in this report include the following:

Correspondence Mail consists of First-Class Mail that is used solely or primarily to deliver (non-sales-related) communications, such as letters, greeting cards, and communications between households and businesses.

Transactions Mail consists of First-Class bills and statements, including mail payments by households, and other transactions mail.

Marketing and Advertising Mail includes Marketing Mail as well as First-Class Mail that includes advertising, and other small categories of advertising mail.

Periodicals consist of magazines, newspapers, and other publications delivered in the mail.

Packages consist of packages delivered by the Postal Service, including packages sent by and received by households.

Table 1.5 presents mail sent and received by households in 2024, organized by the above mail markets, presented in terms of average number of pieces per household.

Correspondence and transaction mail held similar market shares, 14% and 16% respectively.

The advertising market was by far the largest in 2024, accounting for 60% of total household mail. This may come as no surprise, considering mail advertisements' ability to connect local businesses with local customers.

Periodicals now account for a very small portion of total household mail, about 3%, with many magazines and newspapers transitioning to online formats. Packages accounted for 8% of pieces sent or received by households in 2024.

Table 1.5: Pieces Received and Sent per Household – Markets

Mail Market	Pieces per Household per Year	Share of Total Household Mail
Correspondence	97.2	14%
Transactions	111.0	16%
Advertising	409.9	60%
Periodicals	19.9	3%
Packages	51.8	8%
Other	6.0	1%
Total Household Mail	**682.0**	—

Source: HDS Survey, FY 2024. Notes: Correspondence, transactions and packages exclude double-counted pieces reported as both sent and received by households. Advertising includes 13.9 pieces per year of First-Class advertising-enclosed mail that is also included in another category but excluded from total to avoid double-counting. Other includes unclassified First-Class Mail, and CDs and DVD sent by First-Class Mail.

Report Organization

The remainder of this report is organized as follows:

Chapter 2: Demographics and Mail Usage

Chapter 3: Correspondence Mail

Chapter 4: Transactions Mail

Chapter 5: Advertising Mail

Chapter 6: Periodicals

Chapter 7: Packages

In addition, there are two appendices to the report:

Appendix A contains a set of tables for major classes and types of mail.

Appendix B documents the study methodology and discusses how the data were collected, weighted, and adjusted, and compares demographic data in the sample to that of the entire U.S. population based on Census data.

A copy of the instruments used to administer the survey is available upon request.

Chapter 2: Demographics and Mail Usage

Introduction

This chapter provides an overview of demographic trends and other factors affecting mail flows and usage. The breakouts introduced provide the framework for much of the analyses in later chapters.

Mail Volume and Demographics

Table 2.1 illustrates changes in mail volumes and changes in various measures of the size of the U.S. Postal Market. The mail volumes presented here include both household and non-household mail. Subsequent sections will look at household demographics and household mail.

Table 2.1: Mail Volume and Measures of the Size of the Mail Market

	2014	2019	2024	% Change 2014-2024	% Change 2019-2024
Total Mail Volume (billions)	156	143	112	-28%	-21%
Delivery Points (millions)	154	160	169	10%	5%
Households (millions)	123	129	132	7%	3%

Source: U.S. Postal Service - Total Mail Volume and Delivery Points, U.S. Census Bureau - Households.

From 2014 to 2024, total mail volume fell 28%, from 156 billion pieces to 112 billion. During this same period, the number of Postal Service delivery points grew 10%, or about 1% per year, a rate that continued from 2019 to 2024. The total number of U.S households grew at a somewhat slower pace, 7% over the past 10 years and 3% over the past 5 years. Regardless of the measure, the volume of mail has declined while the number of mail users grew.

The last decade saw significant declines in mail volumes even as household formation and delivery points continued to rise.

Tables 2.2 through 2.6 illustrate how certain households' demographic characteristics can affect mail usage more significantly than others. Note that several of the demographic variables presented in this section are aligned with Census data through a weighting process described in Appendix B.

Table 2.2 shows that mail volume is strongly correlated with the age of the household head. Households headed by someone aged 65 or older received or sent 41% of all household mail in 2024, far above their 29% share of the U.S. population. Conversely, household heads aged 18 to 34 made up 20% of households but only accounted for 11% of the total household mail. The shares of mail received or sent by households aged 35 to 64 are close to their shares of total households though even within these age groups, older households mail share was somewhat greater than their population share.

Table 2.2: Age of Household Head and Mail Volume

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Age of Household Head	Received	Sent	Share of total mail	Share of households
18 to 34	359.3	8.5	11%	20%
35-44	518.1	16.3	14%	17%
45-54	667.1	28.8	16%	16%
55-64	723.6	33.6	19%	17%
65 and Over	917.8	55.8	41%	29%

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Table 2.3 shows the relationship between household income and household mail received and sent. The volume of mail received per household increases as household income increases. For mail sent, the relationship between pieces per household and household income is less clear. Combining received and sent mail we see that higher income households ($100,000 and above) share of the mail is greater than their share of population while households with incomes below $65,000 have a lower share of mail than their share of households.

Table 2.3: Household Income and Mail Volume

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Household Income *(Thousands)*	Received	Sent	Share of total mail	Share of households
Under $25,000	420.7	19.5	7%	10%
$25,000-$34,999	495.2	31.1	8%	10%
$35,000-$49,999	610.4	23.9	12%	12%
$50,000-$64,999	636.9	33.8	10%	10%
$65,000-$79,999	644.2	33.8	11%	11%
$80,000-$99,999	649.3	32.2	12%	12%
$100,000-$119,999	730.8	29.3	12%	11%
$120,000-$149,999	793.5	37.8	10%	8%
$150,000 or More	847.9	30.6	20%	15%

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

As Table 2.4 highlights, education is another demographic factor that impacts the volume of household mail received with pieces per household increasing as educational attainment increases. Generally, more educated households also sent more mail. However, the relationship between education and mail volumes is not as strong as that of age or income. For each education level, the share of mail is not much different from the share of households.

Table 2.4: Education of Household Head and Mail Volume
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Educational Attainment of Household Head	Received	Sent	Share of total mail	Share of households
Up to 12th Grade (No Diploma)	557.8	23.9	5%	6%
High School Graduate	625.4	29.4	25%	26%
Some College or Technical School Graduate	670.4	34.5	21%	21%
College Graduate	696.7	32.2	49%	47%

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Table 2.5 shows that homeowners received and sent about twice as much mail as renters. However, it should be noted that homeownership is also correlated with age and income, two other factors which also affect mail volume.

Table 2.5: Homeownership and Mail Volume
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Homeownership Status	Received	Sent	Share of total mail	Share of households
Homeowner	794.4	37.8	79%	66%
Renter	410.9	17.8	21%	34%

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Table 2.6 presents mail volumes depending on whether the household lives in one of the 30 largest MSAs (Metropolitan Statistical Areas) in the U.S., another MSA, or outside of an MSA. Total mail volumes sent and received are not very different across the different MSA classifications. However, as later chapters will show, there are some types of mail where differences between more urbanized and more rural households are important.

Table 2.6: MSA Classification and Mail Volume
(Pieces per Household per Year)

MSA Classification	Received	Sent	Share of total mail	Share of households
Largest MSA	693.9	30.3	46%	44%
Other MSA	642.4	33.0	40%	42%
Non-MSA	627.9	29.0	13%	14%

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Table 2.7 shows changes over time in the different age group's share of total mail and share of total households. This table illustrates a recurring theme regarding household mail – that it is increasingly skewed toward older households. For example, in 2014, households headed by someone age 65 or over accounted for 30% of all household mail and 23% of all households. By 2024, the 65 or over age group accounted for 41% of all mail and 29% of all households.

In contrast, younger households – those headed by someone aged 18 to 34 – saw their share of total mail fall from 14% in 2014 to 11% in 2024, far below their 20% share of total households in 2024.

Table 2.7: Age of Household Head and Mail Volume Shares

(Pieces per Household per Year)

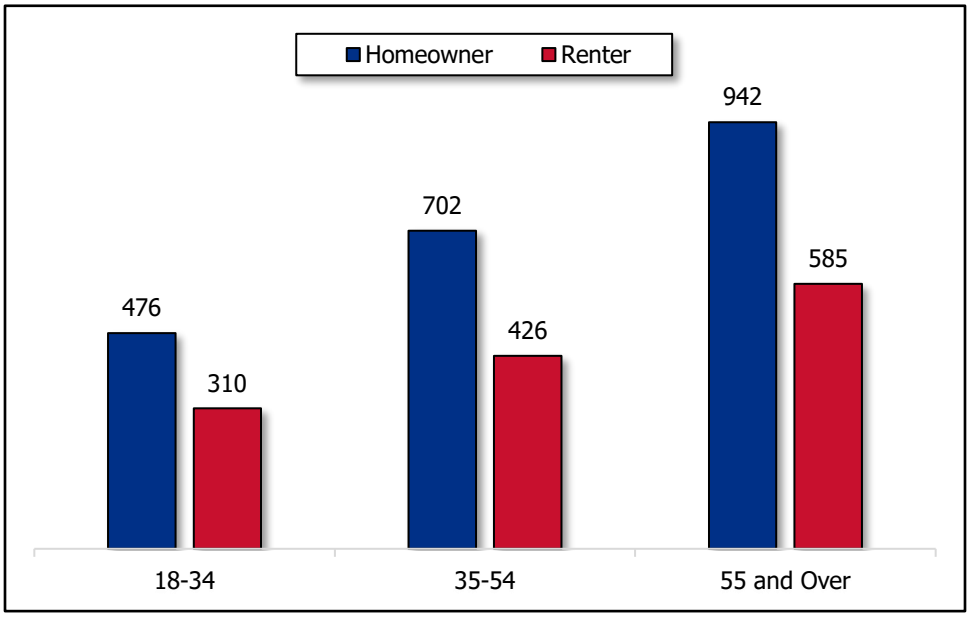
Age of Household Head	2014		2019		2024	
	Share of total mail	Share of households	Share of total mail	Share of households	Share of total mail	Share of households
18 to 34	14%	22%	12%	20%	11%	20%
35-44	15%	18%	13%	17%	14%	17%
45-54	20%	19%	18%	18%	16%	16%
55-64	21%	18%	21%	19%	19%	17%
65 and Over	30%	23%	36%	27%	41%	29%

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Figure 2.1 illustrates the differences in mail volume between homeowners and renters across age groups. Given that homeownership is strongly correlated with the age of household heads, this figure helps isolate the effect of homeownership by comparing renters and homeowners within the same age categories. As shown, homeowners receive approximately 50% more mail pieces than renters within each age group.

Figure 2.1: Mail Pieces by Age and Homeownership

(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Chapter 3: Correspondence Mail

Introduction

This chapter examines the flow of correspondence mail from household to household and between households and businesses, including letters, greeting cards, invitations, and announcements. In several cases, this chapter, and others following it, examine comparisons in data between 2014, 2019, and 2024, providing an illustration of mail trends over time. In 2024, correspondence mail represented 14% of all household mail.

Correspondence Mail Volume

Correspondence mail has declined steadily since the early 2000's, when both personal and business communications began migrating to the internet. As shown in Table 3.1, correspondence mail received by households fell 25% from 2014 and 2024. Over the same period, correspondence mail sent fell 58%, indicating that households are more comfortable using alternatives to the mail for sending correspondence than receiving it. In 2024, households received an average of 93 pieces of correspondence mail and sent an average of 15 pieces. Total correspondence mail received by or sent by households was 97 pieces per year. The total is less than the sum of the individual received and sent volumes because household-to-household correspondence mail is included in both the received and sent categories, but this double-count is removed from the total.

Table 3.1: Total Postal Service Correspondence Volumes

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Received	124.7	109.9	93.2	–25%	–15%
Sent	35.5	26.0	14.9	–58%	–43%
Total	**135.1**	**117.5**	**97.2**	**–28%**	**–17%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Total is adjusted for double count of pieces sent and received between households.

Table 3.2 shows changes in the flow of mail from households and non-households. From 2019 to 2024, first-class correspondence mail sent from households to other households and from households to non-households fell 24% and 47%, respectively. Correspondent mail from non-households to households fell just 13%.

Table 3.2: Household Correspondence by Mail Flow

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Mail Flow	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Household to household	29.2	21.9	16.6	–43%	–24%
Non-household to household	95.5	88.0	76.5	–20%	–13%
Household to non-household	10.3	7.6	4.1	–61%	–47%
Total	**135.1**	**117.5**	**97.2**	**–28%**	**–17%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Totals may not sum due to rounding.

Correspondence mail received by households is somewhat varied as seen in Table 3.3. The largest component is notices/announcements/business invitations at 39 pieces per household in 2024. The volume of this category has been fairly stable over time. Other sizeable types of correspondence mail received include greeting cards, and correspondence related to taxes and insurance. Total correspondence mail received fell from 125 pieces per household in 2014 to 93 per household in 2024, a decline of 25%.

Table 3.3: Household Correspondence Mail Received by Contents

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Type of Mail	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Notice/Announcement/Business Invitation	45.2	39.7	39.1	–14%	–2%
Greeting card	23.9	18.1	15.5	–35%	–14%
Insurance Related (EOBs, etc.)	20.5	19.9	12.2	–41%	–39%
Tax Related	9.1	9.4	8.2	–10%	–12%
Letter or Invitation from a Friend or Relative	8.4	6.0	3.4	–59%	–44%
Other Correspondence Received	17.6	16.7	14.8	–16%	–11%
Total Correspondence Mail Received	**124.7**	**109.9**	**93.2**	**–25%**	**–15%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Totals may not sum due to rounding.

Table 3.4 shows that most correspondence mail sent consists of greeting cards, representing 9.4 of the 14.9 pieces sent in 2024. Holiday greeting cards fell only 9% from 2019 to 2024, compared to a fall of 45% for other greeting cards. On average, households sent less than two personal letters in 2024, 78% less than in 2014. Total correspondence mail sent fell 58% from 2014 to 2024 and 43% from 2019 to 2024.

Table 3.4: Household Correspondence Mail Sent by Contents

(Pieces per Household per Year)

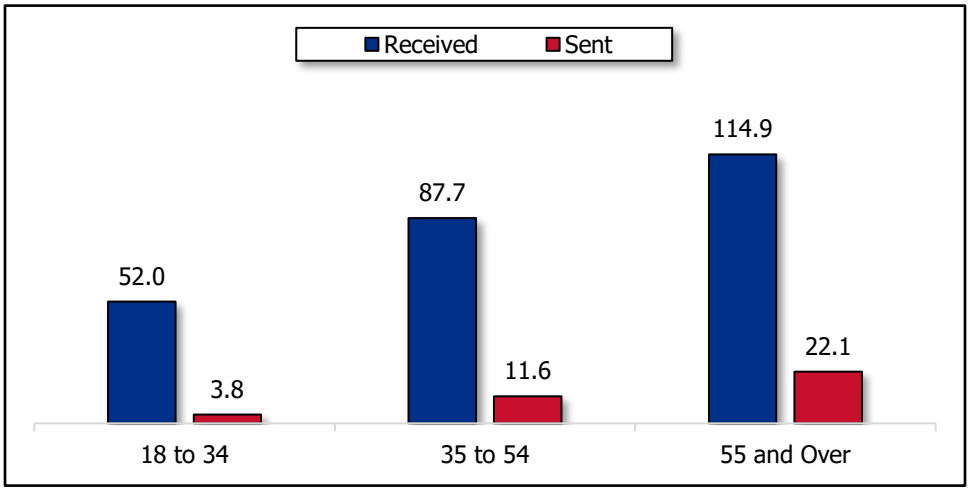
Type of Mail	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Holiday/Seasons Greeting card	7.0	5.2	4.7	–32%	–9%
Other Greeting card	11.6	8.6	4.7	–59%	–45%
Letter/Invitation/Announcement	8.6	5.2	1.9	–78%	–63%
Tax Related	1.7	1.3	0.6	–63%	–52%
Completed form/Application/Paperwork	2.7	1.5	1.0	–63%	–32%
Other Correspondence Sent	4.1	4.3	1.9	–54%	–56%
Total Correspondence Mail Sent	**35.5**	**26.0**	**14.9**	**–58%**	**–43%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Totals may not sum due to rounding.

Correspondence Mail and Household Characteristics

The following figures categorize correspondence mail sent and received by households according to the demographic characteristics developed in Chapter 2. Figure 3.1 shows that household age is a key determinant of household correspondence mail. Households headed by someone 55 or older received more than twice as many pieces as households headed by someone aged 18 to 34. The age difference in mail sent is even greater with the oldest households sending almost six times as much correspondence mail as the youngest households.

Figure 3.1: Correspondence Mail Volumes by Age of Household Head
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Table 3.5 looks at changes in correspondence mail over the past ten years by age of household head. Not only do younger households receive less mail than older households, but their decline in mail volume has also been greater. From 2014 to 2024, households headed by someone aged 18 to 34 years old saw a 45% decline in correspondence mail received, compared with declines of 29% for the 35 to 54 age group and 19% for the 55 and over age group. Since 2019, the age difference is even greater with the decline among younger households being twice as great as for the other age groups.

Table 3.5 also shows that correspondence mail sent by the 18 to 34 age group fell 81% from 2014 to 2024, and 66% from 2019 to 2024, reflecting their greater communication through use of digital technologies.

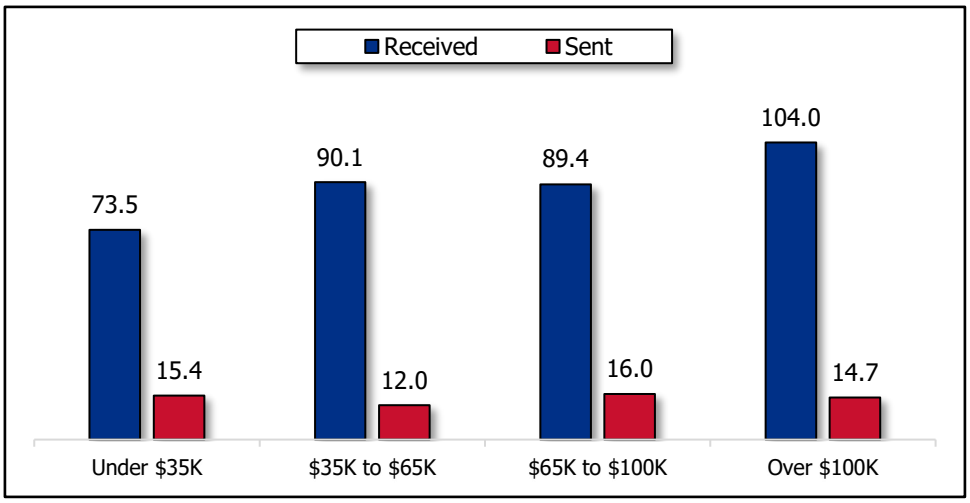
Table 3.5: Correspondence Mail Volumes by Age of Household Head
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Age of Household Head	2014	2019	2024	% Change 2014–2024	% Change 2019–2024
Received					
18 to 34	94.0	72.3	52.0	-45%	-28%
35 to 54	123.3	101.9	87.7	-29%	-14%
55 and Over	141.9	132.1	114.9	-19%	-13%
All households	**124.7**	**109.9**	**93.2**	**-25%**	**-15%**
Sent					
18 to 34	19.8	11.1	3.8	-81%	-66%
35 to 54	31.8	20.9	11.6	-64%	-45%
55 and Over	46.8	36.1	22.1	-53%	-39%
All households	**35.5**	**26.0**	**14.9**	**-58%**	**-43%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample.

Figure 3.2 shows that household income also affects the volume of correspondence mail received. Households with an annual income over $100,000 received about 40% more correspondence mail than households earning less than $35,000 and about 15% more than households earning between $35,000 and $100,000. On the other hand, there is not a clear relationship between household income and correspondence mail sent with all income groups sending about 15 pieces per household in 2024.

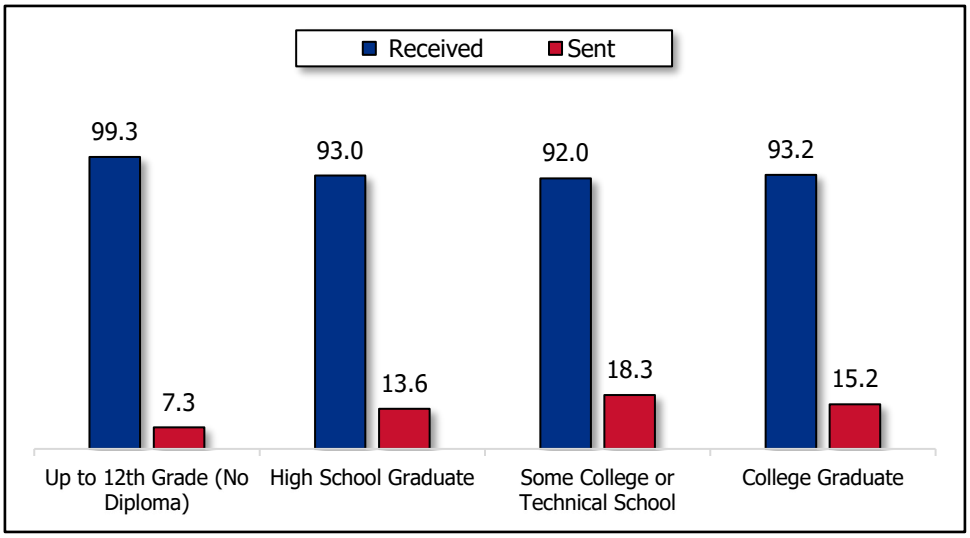
Figure 3.2: Correspondence Mail Volumes by Household Income
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

An interesting result is found in Figure 3.3 which looks at correspondence mail by education of the household head. Mail received is about the same across all education levels, ranging between 92 and 100 pieces per year. Education has more of an impact on correspondence mail sent with households headed by someone without a high school diploma sending an average of just 7 pieces per year. The other education groups sent roughly twice as much.

Figure 3.3: Correspondence Mail Volumes by Education of Household Head
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Table 3.6 shows how correspondence mail volumes have changed over time for different education levels. College graduates had the largest decline in correspondence received in the last decade, dropping 35% from 2014 to 2024. Meanwhile, household heads without a high school diploma experienced a 4% increase in mail received in the last decade. However, these households saw significantly greater declines in correspondence mail sent, with those without a high school diploma sending 71% less than a decade ago, and those with some college or technical school sending 46% less.

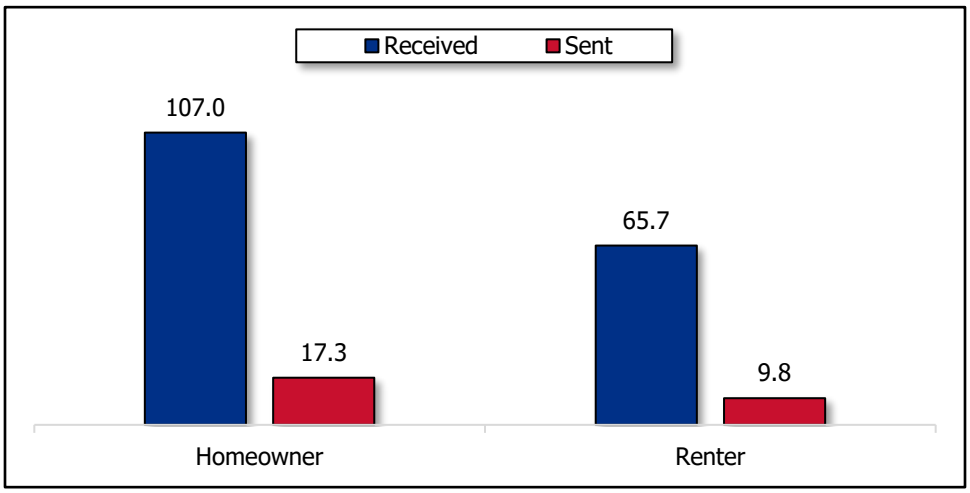
Table 3.6: Correspondence Mail Volumes by Education of Household Head
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Education of Household Head	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Received					
Up to 12th Grade (No Diploma)	95.2	103.0	99.3	4%	-4%
High School Graduate	112.5	108.7	93.0	-17%	-14%
Some College or Technical School	123.2	109.4	92.0	-25%	-16%
College Graduate	143.4	112.9	93.2	-35%	-17%
All households	**124.7**	**109.9**	**93.2**	**-25%**	**-15%**
Sent					
Up to 12th Grade (No Diploma)	25.0	19.5	7.3	-71%	-62%
High School Graduate	31.2	22.1	13.6	-57%	-38%
Some College or Technical School	34.1	25.1	18.3	-46%	-27%
College Graduate	42.8	30.3	15.2	-65%	-50%
All households	**35.5**	**26.0**	**14.9**	**-58%**	**-43%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample.

Homeowners send and receive more mail than renters, recognizing that homeownership is correlated with age and income, two other factors shown to impact correspondence mail volumes.

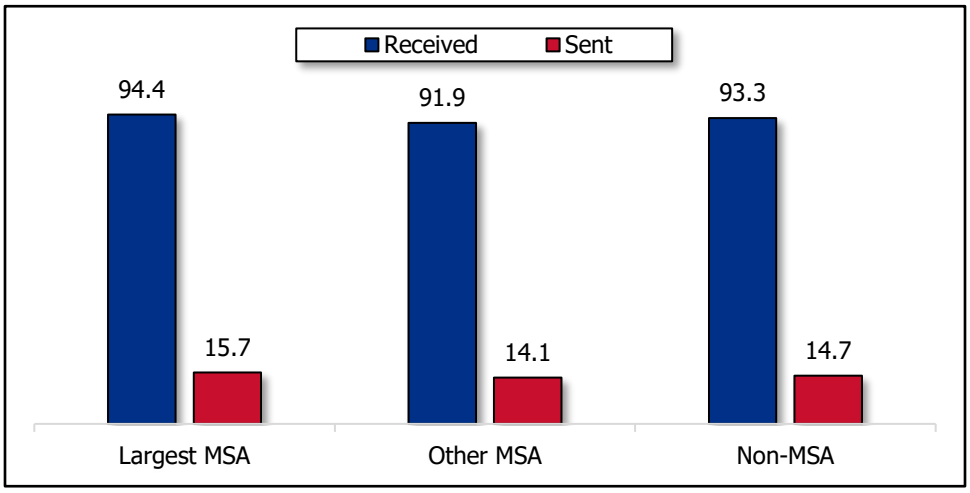
Figure 3.4: Correspondence Mail Volumes by Homeownership
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Finally, Figure 3.5 shows the correspondence mail volumes for household living in different metro classifications. There was very little difference in correspondence mail based on household MSA classification.

Figure 3.5: Correspondence Mail Volumes by MSA Classification
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Chapter 4: Transactions

Transaction Mail

This chapter examines the volumes and types of transaction mail sent and received by households. Transaction categories include bills, statements, payments, donations, and rebates. In 2024, its volume accounted for 16% of total household mail.

Starting in the early 2000s, household bill payments began shifting from the mail to electronic payment methods such as online payments or payments automatically deducted from a bank account. The shift of bills and statements (also referred to as presentments) received by mail started later and moved more slowly than the diversion of mail payments, reflected in the smaller decline in transactions mail received compared to transactions mail sent. Nevertheless, electronic diversion continues to be the key driver of the decline in transaction mail over the past five and ten years.

As Table 4.1 illustrates, total household transaction mail fell from 215 pieces in 2014 to 159 pieces in 2019 and 111 pieces in 2024, a decline of 48% over the past ten years. Transactions received are dominated by bills and statements, which together represented about 85 of the 100 pieces received per household in 2024, though both have declined by more than 40% over the past ten years.

Transaction mail sent by households consists mostly of payments with an average of just less than 9 pieces per household in 2024. Payment volumes have fallen 76% over the past decade and 60% over just the past five years.

Table 4.1: Transaction Mail Received and Sent

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Transaction Type	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Received					
Bills	115.2	89.2	63.8	-45%	-28%
Statements	36.6	29.0	21.1	-42%	-27%
Requests for Donation	4.8	3.7	3.4	-28%	-8%
Other	17.2	12.8	11.6	-33%	-9%
Total Received	**173.8**	**134.7**	**99.9**	**-43%**	**-26%**
Sent					
Payments	36.7	21.8	8.8	-76%	-60%
Donations	2.6	1.9	1.9	-29%	-3%
Other	2.0	1.1	0.7	-65%	-39%
Total Sent	**41.3**	**24.9**	**11.4**	**-72%**	**-54%**
Total Transactions	**214.7**	**159.1**	**111.0**	**-48%**	**-30%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Total is adjusted for double count of pieces sent and received between households.

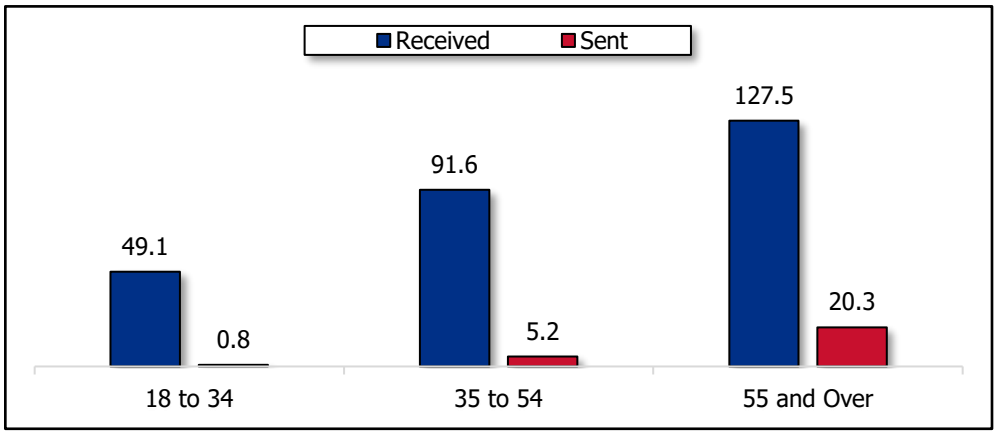
Transaction Mail and Household Characteristics

The following sections examine transaction mail sent and received by households based on the demographic characteristics outlined in Chapter 2.

As illustrated in Figure 4.1, age had a strong influence on the volume of transaction mail sent and received by households. Younger heads of household (under 35) sent and received the lowest number of transaction mail pieces, averaging 49.1 and 0.8 pieces per year respectively. In short, younger households do not use the mail to send transactions. No doubt this is tied to younger households' greater familiarity with and use of technological alternatives to the mail.

In contrast, the oldest cohort (55 or older) received the most transaction pieces, averaging 128 pieces per year, or about 2.5 times more than was received by the youngest cohort. For mail sent the difference is far greater with the oldest households sending more than 20 pieces of transactions mail, far more than the youngest age group and four times as many as sent by households headed by someone 35 to 54 years old.

Figure 4.1: Transactions Mail Volumes by Age of Household Head
(Pieces per Household per Year)

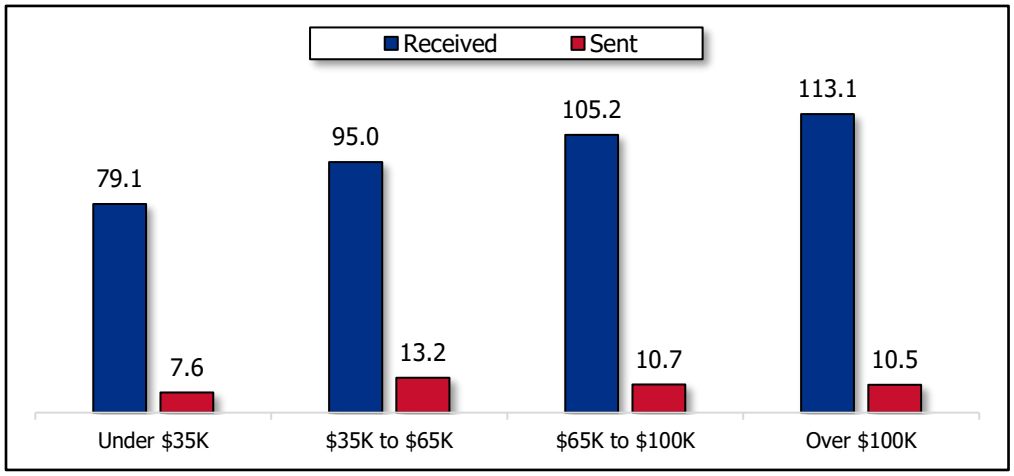


Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Heads of household older than 55 received two and half times more transaction mail than heads under 35

Figure 4.2 shows the influence of household income on transaction mail volumes. As household income increases so does the amount of transactions mail received by a household. This largely reflects the fact that higher income households are likely to have more financial accounts. The amount of mail sent was mixed, with the lowest income group (under $35K) sending the fewest pieces but the next lowest income group ($35K to $65K) sending the most. Different factors at both the low and high ends of the income spectrum may contribute to lower mail volume, such as fewer bills sent to lower-income households and higher digital literacy among higher-income households.

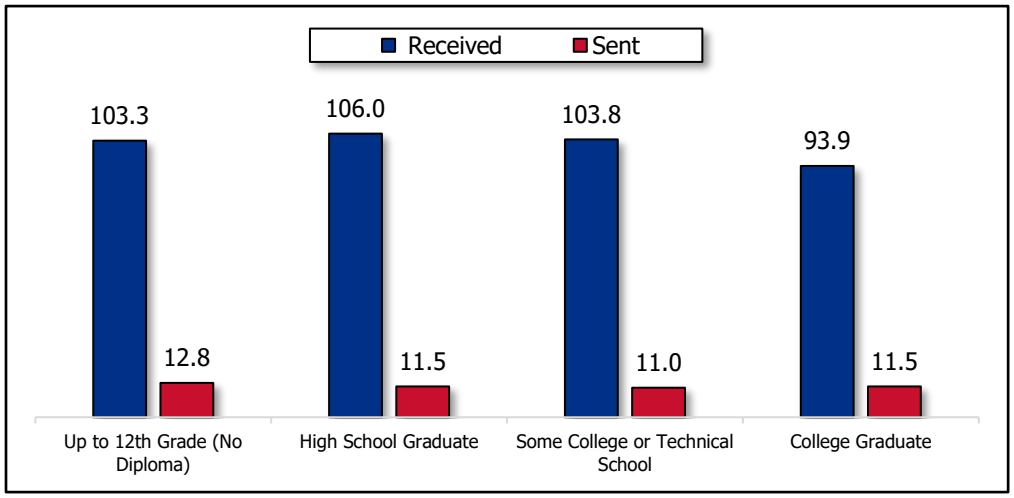
Figure 4.2: Transactions Mail Volumes by Household Income
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Figure 4.3 illustrates that education has a weak effect on transactions mail received or sent. Households headed by a college graduate received the fewest pieces on average but there was no meaningful difference across the other education groups. Transactions mail sent was also roughly equal across all four education groups.

Figure 4.3: Transactions Mail Volumes by Education of Household Head
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Bills and Statements Received by Households

Bills and statements (also known as presentments) comprise most household transactions mail. This section of the report looks at this mail in greater detail. Table 4.2 shows a breakdown of household bills and statements received by industry of sender. Note that for classification purposes, credit card bill statements are considered bills in Table 4.2.

Table 4.2: Bills and Statements Received by Household by Industry
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Industry	Bills	Statements
Financial	**30.9**	**19.1**
Credit card	18.5	0.1
Bank/Credit Union/Loan Company	3.3	10.8
Insurance Company	7.2	1.2
Other Financial	1.8	6.9
Stores/Retailers	**1.2**	**0.1**
Services	**27.6**	**1.2**
Electric/Gas/Water/Utility/Telephone company	16.7	0.2
Medical or other Professional	9.1	0.8
Other Services	1.8	0.2
Government/Social/Nonprofit	**3.6**	**0.5**
Other	**0.6**	**0.1**
Total – All Industries	**63.8**	**21.1**

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Note: 'Other' includes transactions mail to or from manufacturers, or a friend or relative.

The financial sector is the largest sender of both bills and statements to households, accounting for about half of all bills and 90% of all statements received by mail. Utility bills represent about one-fourth of all bills received. In 2024, households received an average of 64 bills and 21 statements through the mail.

Mailed vs. Online Bills and Statements

As shown in Table 4.1, bills and statements received by households have been declining over at least the past ten years. This decline is a direct result of the shift from mail to online presentments. The HDS recruitment survey includes information about household use of mailed and online presentments which are the basis for the next section.

Table 4.3 shows the annual share of bills, statements, and total presentments received by mail vs. online. The share of bills received by mail has declined from 78% of the total in 2014 to 53% in 2024. The share of statements received experienced a similar decline during this period as more and more households have opted to receive bills and statements online.

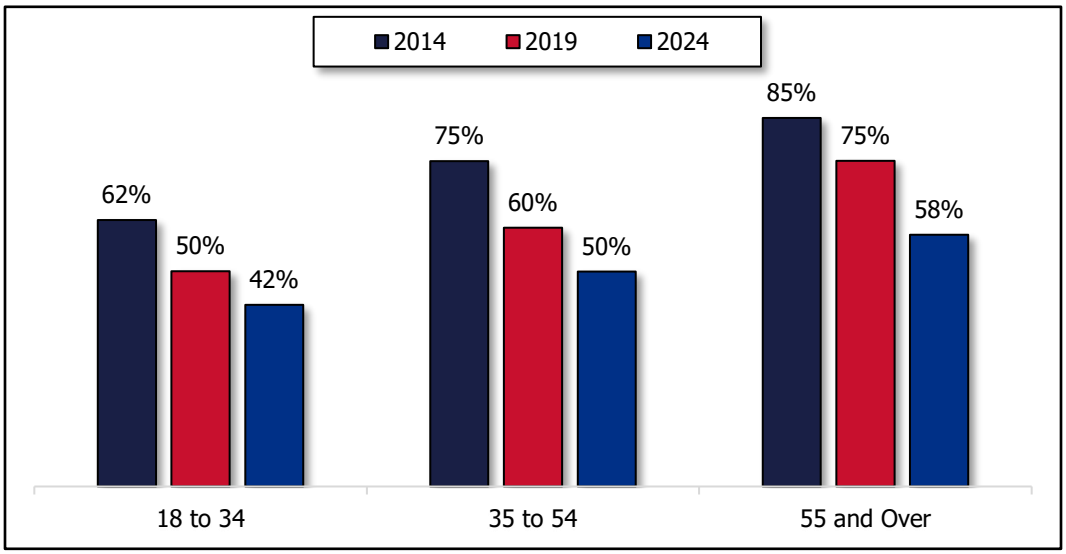
Table 4.3: Mail Share of Total Bills and Statements Received by Households

	2014	2019	2024
Bills	78%	67%	53%
Statements	74%	62%	52%
All	**77%**	**65%**	**52%**

Source: HDS Recruitment Sample.

Figure 4.4 shows the annual share of presentments (bills and statements) received by mail by age of the household head in 2014, 2019, and 2024. Two conclusions can be drawn. First, younger households have for at least the past decade received a lower share of their presentments by mail. The second conclusion is that the mail share has declined similarly across all age groups. Interestingly, the mail share of households headed by someone 55 or older in 2024 (58%) was lower than the 2014 share for households headed by someone 18 to 34. This indicates that the shift from mail to online presentments is likely to continue as older households become more and more comfortable with online presentments. That said, even among the youngest households, a sizeable share of presentments continues to be received by mail.

Figure 4.4: Mail Presentment Shares by Age of Household Head

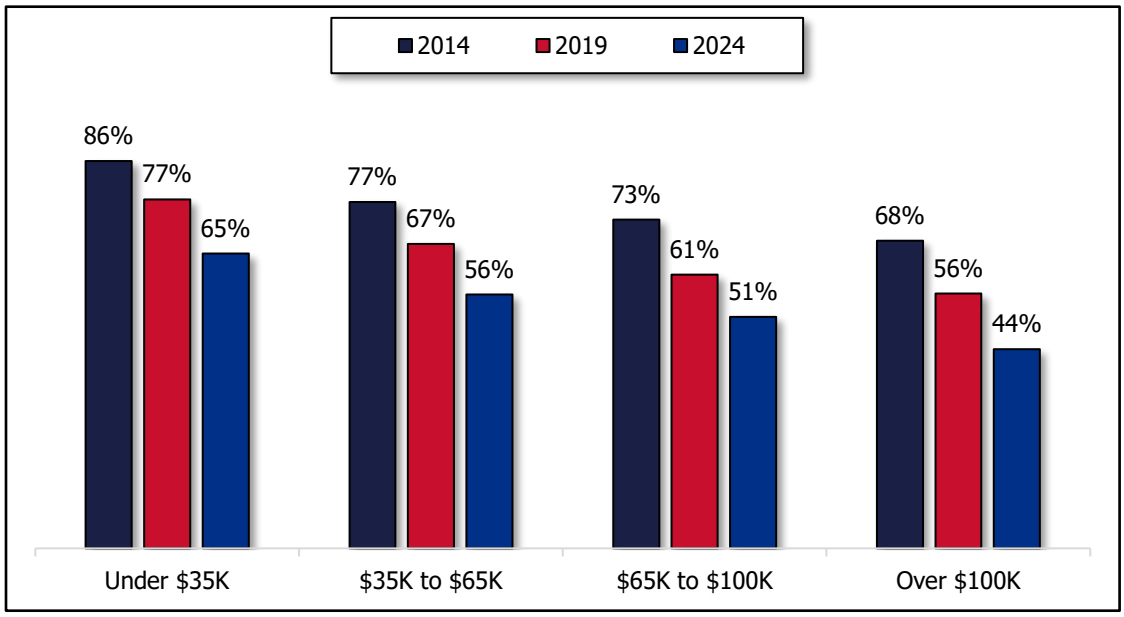


Source: HDS Recruitment Sample, FY 2024.

Figures 4.5 and 4.6 show the mail presentment shares by household income and education of the head of the household in 2014, 2019, and 2024. The figures are similar because of the high correlation between income and education. As both income and education increase, the mail presentment share decreases. One reason is that higher income and higher education households are more likely to have had internet service for a longer period of time and are therefore more familiar with receiving information online. A second reason is that higher income and higher education households receive more presentments and so it may be more valuable to spend the time needed to establish online presentment arrangements with companies.

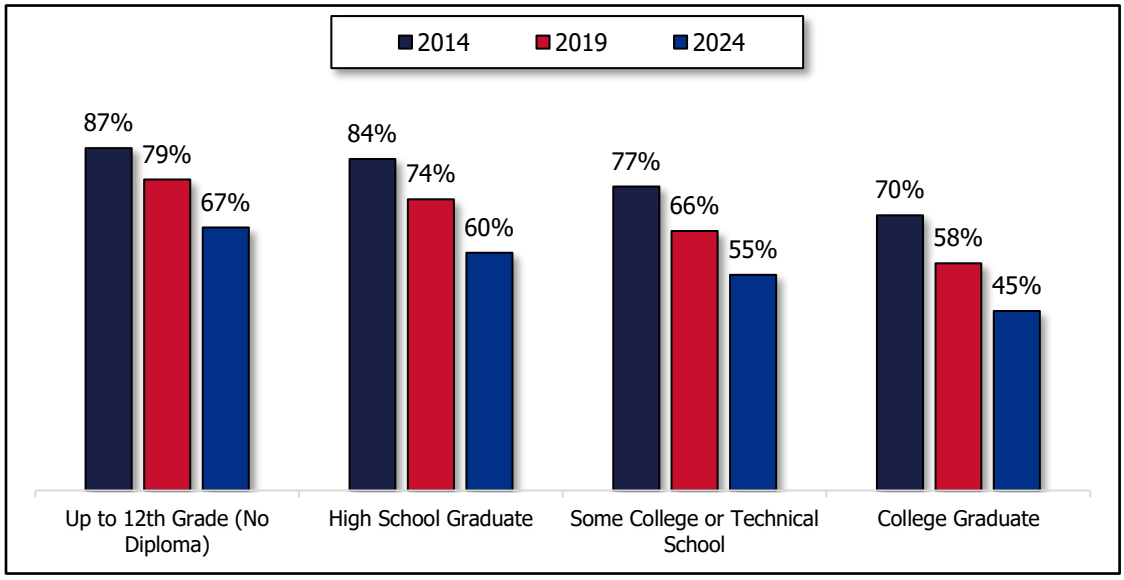
Figures 4.5 and 4.6 also show that regardless of income or education level, the share of presentments by mail declined by about 20 percentage points over the past ten years and by about 10 percentage points over the past five years.

Figure 4.5: Mail Presentment Shares by Household Income



Source: HDS Recruitment Sample

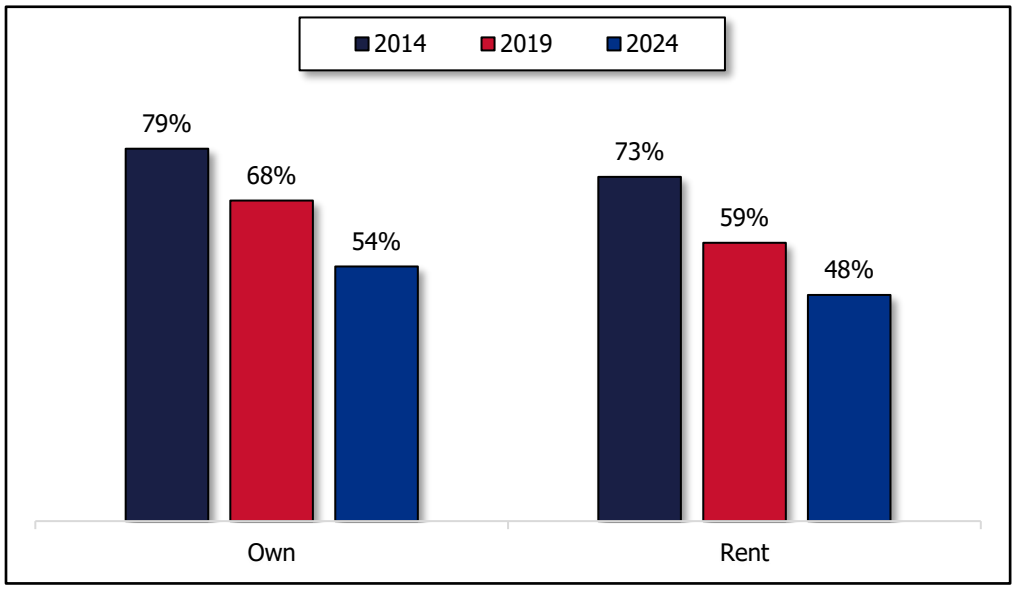
Figure 4.6: Mail Presentment Shares by Education of Household Head



Source: HDS Recruitment Sample

Figure 4.7 shows mail presentment shares for homeowners and renters. In most of the other data in this report there have been large differences between homeowners and renters. Figure 4.7 is the exception. The mail presentment share for homeowners in 2024 was 54%, not much different from the 48% share for renters. This is due to a combination of offsetting effects. Renters are more likely to be younger than homeowners, which contributes to a lower mail presentment share, but renters are also likely to have lower incomes than homeowners which as shown in Figure 4.5 is associated with a higher mail presentment share.

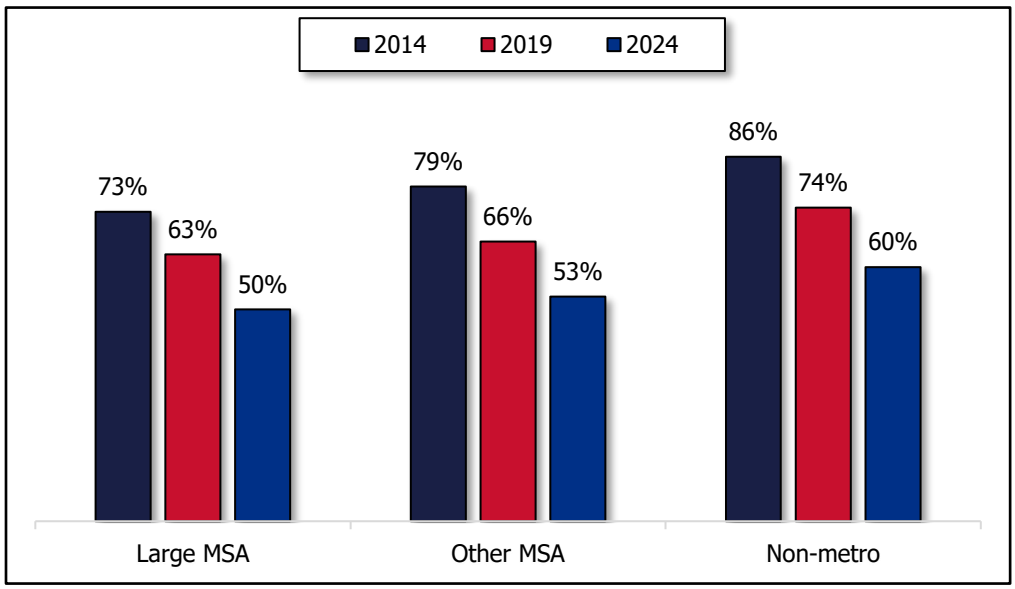
Figure 4.7: Mail Presentment Shares by Homeownership



Source: HDS Recruitment Sample.

Figure 4.8 shows that households living outside of an MSA have a higher mail presentment share than more urbanized households. This may be because of a lower quality of internet access in some rural communities.

Figure 4.8: Mail Presentment Shares by MSA Classification



Source: HDS Recruitment Sample.

Table 4.4 below reports the main reasons households give for receiving bills and statements by mail. Interestingly, 42% of households say they receive bills and statements by mail because they have not set up online presentments, while 27% say it is because the company only sends bills or statements by mail. The benefit of mail for record keeping was also cited by 42% of households. Almost one-fifth of households said that receiving presentments by mail is more convenient than receiving them online and 18% said that

mail is preferred because they view it as having greater security and privacy. Finally, 27% of households receive presentments by mail because that is the way they have always done it.

Table 4.4: Reasons for Receiving Bills and Statements by Mail

Reason	Percent of Households
Have not set things up to receive bills or statements online	42%
Record Keeping	42%
Company only sends bills or statements by mail (or does not send them online)	27%
I have always done it this way	27%
Convenience (Ease of use/Saves time)	19%
Security/Privacy	18%

Source: HDS Recruitment Sample, FY 2024. Note: Respondents may choose multiple answers.

Household Bill Payments

Household bill payments have been even more impacted than presentments by the shift away from the mail. Table 4.5 shows that the mail share of household bill payments, which was just 33% in 2014, fell to 23% in 2019 and 13% in 2024. During this time, the share of bill payments made using the internet, or by automatic deduction from a bank account or credit card, all rose steadily. This suggests that one reason why the mail payment share of presentments is higher than for payments is that there are more non-mail payments options for mail payments than mail presentments for which the only option is online.

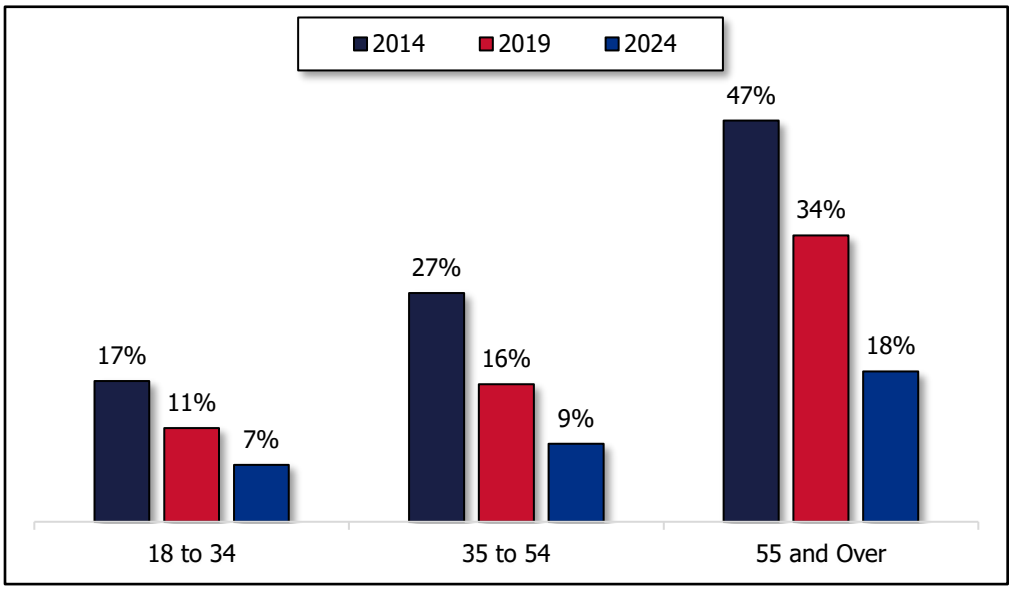
Table 4.5: Bill Payment Shares by Method

Bill Payment Method	Share of Bills Paid by Method		
	2014	2019	2024
Mail	33%	23%	13%
Using Internet	41%	48%	51%
Automatic Payment*	18%	22%	31%
Telephone	3%	4%	2%
In-person	4%	3%	2%
Total	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**

Source: HDS Recruitment Sample. Note: "Automatic Payment" includes automatic deduction from bank account and automatic charge to debit or credit card.

Age of the household head is by far the most important demographic variable affecting the mail share of bill payments, as seen in Figure 4.9. Households headed by someone aged 18 to 34 paid only 7% of their bills by mail in 2024 while households headed by someone aged 35 to 54 paid just 9% by mail. Even among households headed by someone aged 55 or older the mail payment share was only 18%, about equal to the mail payment share of the youngest households in 2014. There has also been a large decline in the mail payment share of these older households, which has fallen from 47% in 2014.

Figure 4.9: Mail Payment Shares by Age of Household Head



Source: HDS Recruitment Sample, FY 2024.

The impact of other demographic factors on the mail payment share is similar to these impacts on the mail presentment share. Households with higher incomes and higher levels of education have a lower mail payment share. The mail payment shares of homeowners and renters are not much different. Households in less urbanized areas have a somewhat higher mail payment share than households living in an MSA.

Although most households pay most of their bills by methods other than the mail, many households continue to use the mail for at least some of their bill payments. For these households, 29% report that they pay bills by mail because they have not set up alternative payment methods. About one quarter of mail paying households report that the biller prefers or requires payments by mail, with one quarter of households mentioning record keeping and their traditional habits as reasons for paying bills by mail. Security and privacy issues were a reason for payments by mail given by 19% of respondents with 14% listing the convenience and/or ease of use of mail payments as a reason.

Table 4.6: Reasons for Paying Bills by Mail by Households that Pay Bills by Mail

Reason	Percent of Households
Have not set things up to pay electronically	29%
Biller prefers/requires payment by mail	25%
Record Keeping	25%
I have always done it this way	25%
Security/Privacy	19%
Convenience (Ease of use/Saves time)	14%

Source: HDS Recruitment Sample, FY 2024. Note: Respondents may choose multiple answers.

Chapter 5: Marketing and Advertising Mail

Introduction

This chapter examines marketing and advertising mail received by households which collectively will be referred to as advertising mail. Marketing and advertising mail includes Marketing Mail, First-Class Mail that contains advertising, and other mail delivered by the USPS that is predominantly advertising. It represented about 60% of all household mail in 2024.

The Advertising Mail Market

As Table 5.1 highlights, the volume of advertising mail has declined over the last 10 years. In 2014 households received an average of 674 pieces of advertising mail per year. By 2024, the number had fallen by 39% to 410 pieces per year. The growth of digital advertising (online, e-mail, social media, text etc.) has been a key driver of the decline in advertising mail received by households. Another key event was the Covid pandemic and the economic and social disruptions it created, which further reduced the amount of advertising mail since 2019. Although not shown in Table 5.1, advertising mail has increased in some years since 2014, with a meaningful rebound occurring in 2021 and 2022 as the pandemic's impacts waned.

Table 5.1: Advertising Mail Received by Households by Mail Classification

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Mail Classification	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014-2024	% change 2019-2024
First-Class Mail Advertising	**73.3**	**58.3**	**36.8**	**-50%**	**-37%**
Advertising-Only	31.9	30.9	23.0	-28%	-26%
Secondary Advertising	41.5	27.4	13.9	-67%	-49%
Marketing Mail Advertising	**580.9**	**512.5**	**357.4**	**-38%**	**-30%**
Commercial	479.7	420.3	282.3	-41%	-33%
Nonprofit	101.2	92.2	75.1	-26%	-19%
Other	**19.3**	**17.0**	**15.8**	**-18%**	**-7%**
Unsolicited Periodicals	10.4	9.1	8.3	-20%	-9%
Unaddressed Mail	8.9	7.9	7.4	-17%	-6%
Total Advertising	**673.5**	**587.8**	**409.9**	**-39%**	**-30%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Totals may not sum due to rounding.

Most advertising mail is Marketing Mail, with Commercial Marketing Mail representing the largest category with 282 pieces received per household in 2024. Marketing Nonprofit Mail, sent by organizations that qualify for reduced nonprofit postage rates, is the second largest category with 75 pieces per household. Note that while 2024 was an election year, FY2024 ended more than a month before the election and does not include the large portion of political advertising mail sent after September 30, 2024. FY2019 includes political advertising received in October and early November of 2018.

Households received 37 pieces of First-Class advertising in 2024. First-Class advertising includes mailings that were advertising-only as well as mail in which advertising was included with a mailing having a different

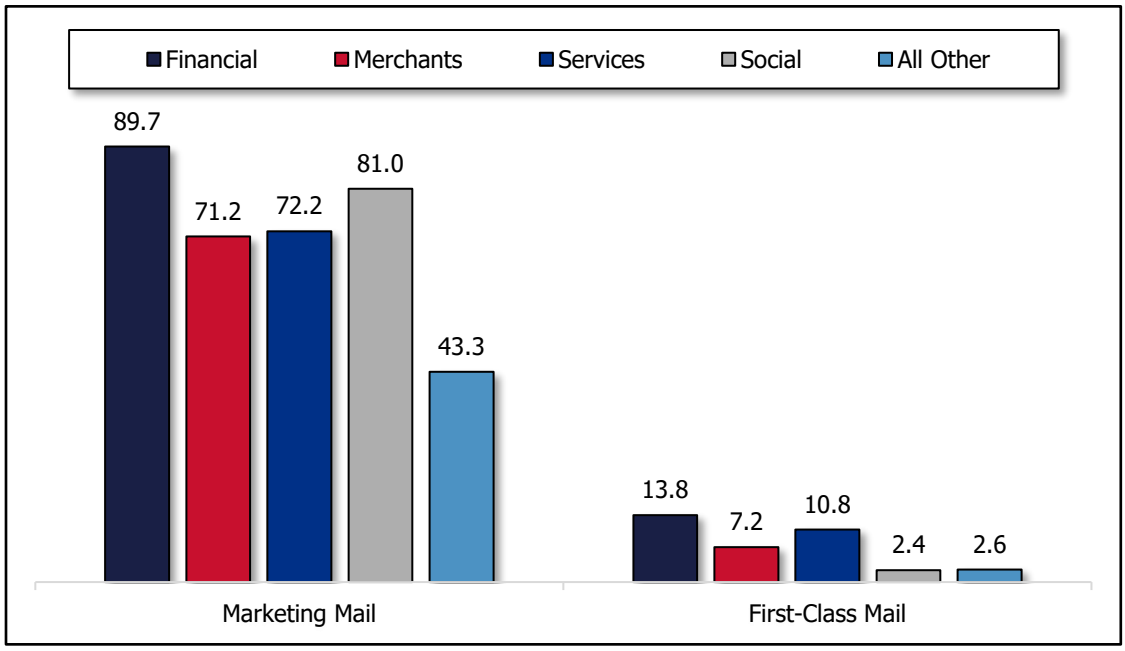
purpose such as an advertising enclosed with a bill or statement. Unless otherwise stated, First-Class advertising mail volumes include both ad-only and ad-enclosed pieces.

Table 5.1 shows that the volume of First-Class advertising has declined 50% since 2014 and 37% since 2019, more than the 38% and 30% declines in Marketing Mail over the same periods. The larger decline in First-Class advertising reflects the general decline in First-Class Mail. Moreover, First-Class Mail is more expensive than Marketing Mail and though it provides a superior level of service, the higher cost has likely caused some marketers to shift their mail advertising to the less expensive Marketing option.

Senders of Advertising Mail

Figure 5.1 shows Marketing Mail and First-Class advertising mail received by households from key mailing industries. In 2024, the financial industry sent the most advertising, for both Marketing and First-Class Mail. Social organizations, including charities and political groups, were the second largest senders of Marketing Mail. Much of this mail is sent at the lower postage rates available to nonprofits, which is one reason why social organization mail is only a small portion of First-Class advertising for which this reduced rate does not exist. Merchants (stores and other retailers) and the Service industry were also main contributors of advertising mail sent to households.

Figure 5.1: Advertising Volumes Received by Households by Sender Industry
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising.

Table 5.2 displays industry advertising mailing trends over the past decade, revealing that Merchants experienced the sharpest decline in advertising volumes, with a 61% reduction. A key factor driving the decline in advertising mail sent by merchants was the closing of many brick and mortar retail stores over the past decade as consumers have shifted from in-store shopping to online purchases. In contrast, the Social industry saw the smallest decrease, with volumes shrinking by 21% over the same period. Note that because Table 5.2 shows per household measures, the growth in the total number of U.S. households over time mitigates some of the loss in total advertising mail.

Table 5.2: Volumes of Marketing and First-Class Ads by Industry

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Sender Type	2014	2019	2024	% Change 2014-2024	% Change 2019-2024
Financial	153.1	154.9	103.5	-32%	-33%
Merchants	202.8	144.6	78.4	-61%	-46%
Services	116.4	103.3	83.0	-29%	-20%
Social	106.1	100.1	83.4	-21%	-17%
All Other	75.8	68.0	45.9	-39%	-32%

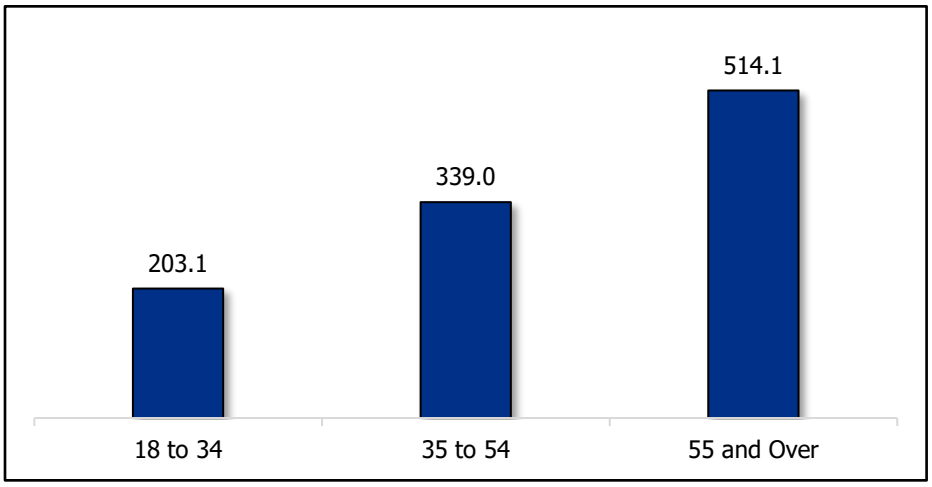
Source: HDS Diary Sample. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising.

Advertising Mail and Household Demographics

Figures 5.2 through 5.6 shows 2024 advertising mail volumes per household across different household demographics. Figure 5.2 shows that the age of the household head is a key factor affecting advertising mail received. Households headed by someone aged 55 and over received an average of 514 pieces of advertising mail in 2024, 2.5 times as much as the 203 pieces received by households headed by someone aged 18 to 34. Several factors explain this difference. First, as shown in Chapter 2, mail is disproportionately received by older households, in part because of younger households' greater familiarity with technological alternatives to the mail. Second, older households have a longer buying history and have had more time for marketers to develop relationships with these customers. Third, age is correlated with income and homeownership, two other factors which will be shown to impact the amount of advertising mail received.

Figure 5.2: Advertising Mail Received by Age of Household Head

(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising.

Table 5.3 shows trends in advertising mail received by the age of the household head. Unsurprisingly, younger age groups all witnessed steeper declines in advertising mail received than their older counterparts. The 18 to 34 age group experienced the largest decline from 2014 to 2024, with volumes reduced to roughly half of what they were ten years earlier for the same demographic. Households whose head was 55 years or older received 36% less advertising mail than the same age group had ten years ago. The difference in the decline is likely explained by younger generations preference for digital media.

Table 5.3: Advertising Mail Received by Age of Household Head

(Pieces per Household per Year)

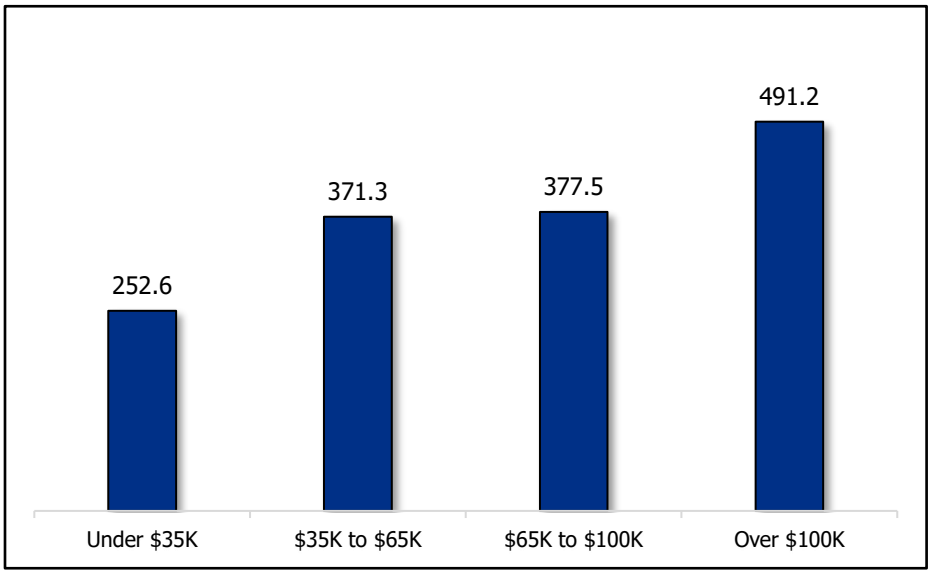
Age of Household Head	2014	2019	2024	% Change 2014-2024	% Change 2019-2024
18 to 34	410.4	329.9	203.1	-51%	-38%
35 to 54	618.9	519.7	339.0	-45%	-35%
55 and Over	809.6	712.8	514.1	-36%	-28%
All Households	**654.2**	**570.8**	**394.2**	**-40%**	**-31%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising.

Given that advertising mail is used to sell goods and services, it is not surprising that the volume of advertising mail received by households is closely tied to their income. As Figure 5.3 illustrates, in 2024, the relationship between advertising mail and household income was quite strong. As an example, households with incomes of $100,000 or more received about twice as many pieces per year as those earning less than $35,000, and roughly 30% more than households with incomes between $35,000 and $100,000.

Figure 5.3: Advertising Mail Received by Household Income

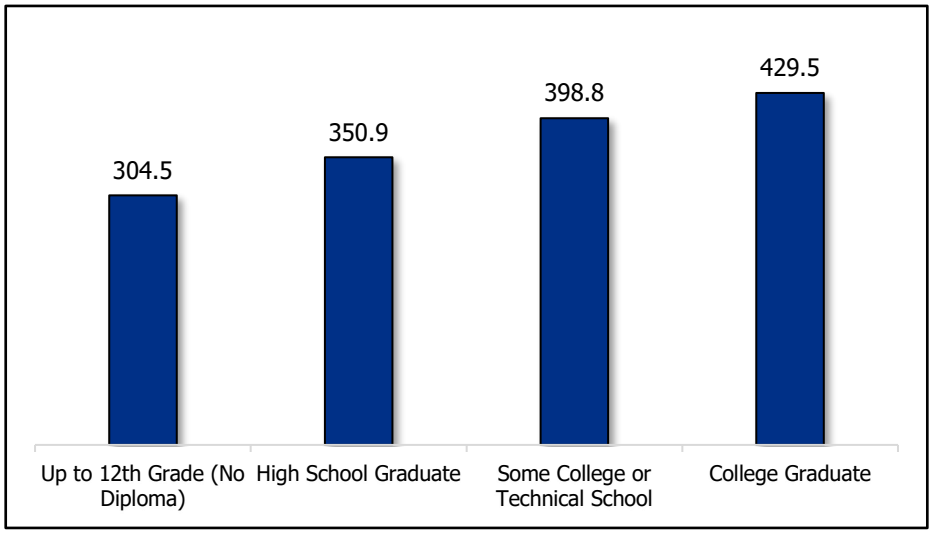
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising.

Figure 5.4 shows that education also played a key role in the volume of advertising mail received with pieces per household rising with increasing levels of education. In general, the role that education plays in advertising mail is two-fold. First, direct mail is a written type of communication, and education may play some role in its relative effectiveness compared to other forms of advertising such as television. Second, education is not only tied to current household income, but also to future household income. A college graduate who currently has a relatively low income may, in a few years, earn a much higher income, and become a more attractive customer for marketers.

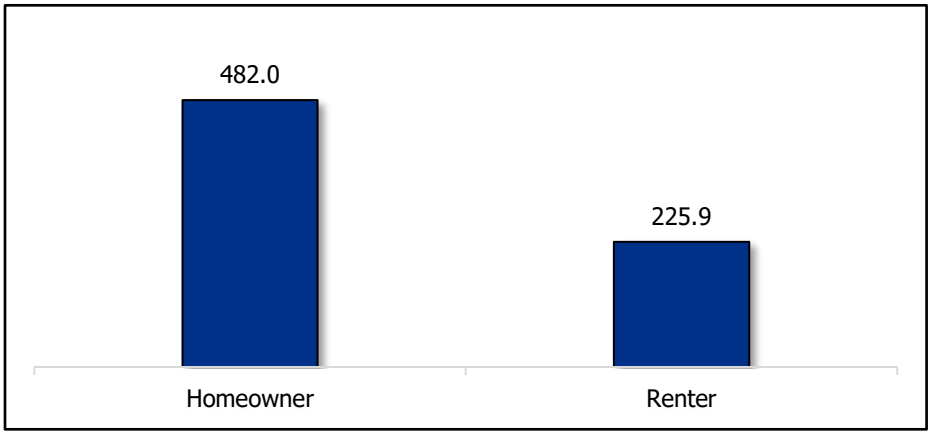
Figure 5.4: Advertising Mail Received by Education of Household Head
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising.

Homeownership played a key role in the amount of advertising mail received by households. As shown in Figure 5.5, homeowners received more than twice as many pieces as renters, with 482 and 226 pieces per year, respectively. Much of this relationship is due to higher income and older average age of homeowners compared to renters. However, it is also the case that homeowners, being less likely to move in any given year than renters, represent a more stable demographic for reaching customers through delivery of advertising mail to their residence.

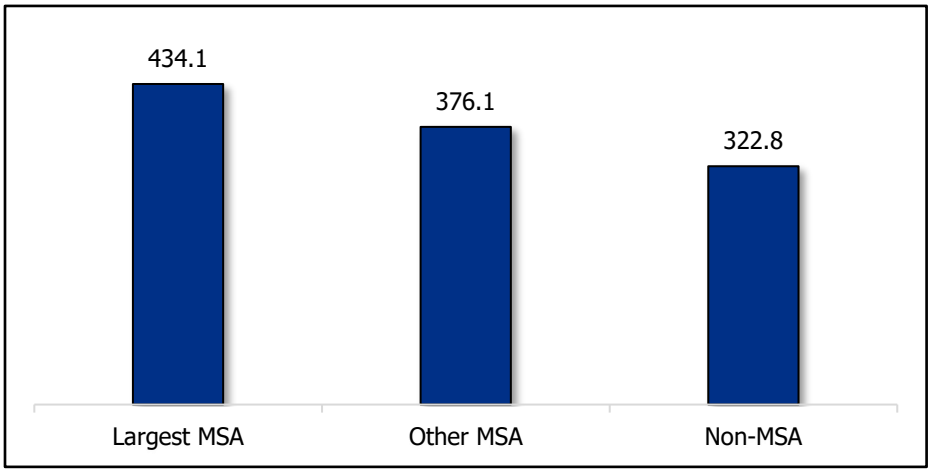
Figure 5.5: Advertising Mail Received by Homeownership
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising.

Figure 5.6 shows that advertising mail volumes are tied to the level of urbanicity, with households living in one of the 30 largest MSAs receiving about one-third more advertising mail than households living outside an MSA. One reason for this is that densely populated areas make it easier for direct mailers to satisfy mailing requirements that provide discounts for bulk mailings, such as a minimum number of pieces per ZIP code or carrier route.

Figure 5.6: Advertising Mail Received by MSA Classification
(Pieces per Household per Year)

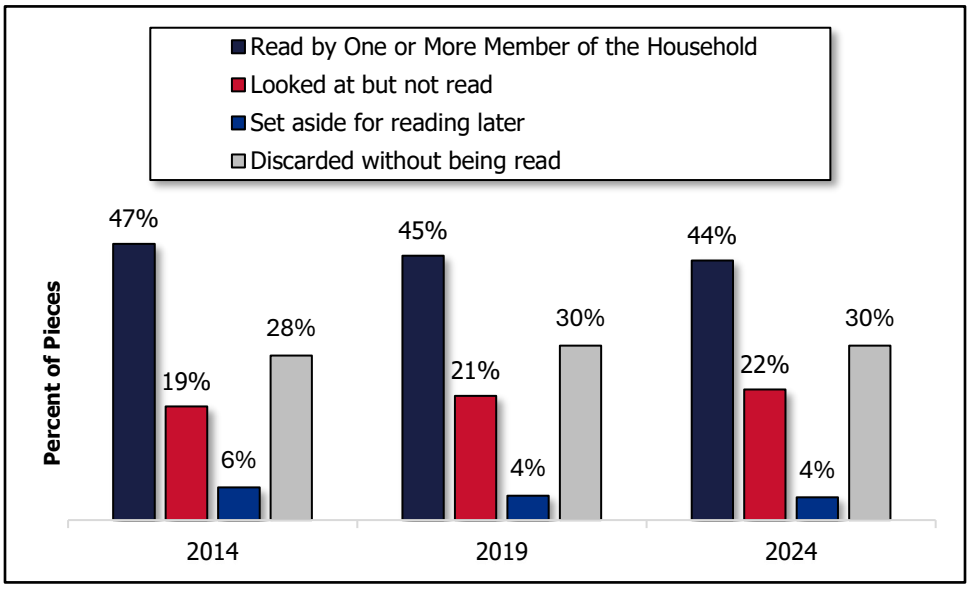


Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising.

Attitudes toward Advertising

The household diary survey reveals that most households either read or at least looked at their advertising mail pieces. In Figure 5.7 we see that one or more household members read 44% of the advertising pieces the household received, down a bit from the 45% reading rate in 2019 and the 47% rate in 2014. In 2024, another 22% of pieces were looked at but not read by a household member and 4% were set aside for reading later. That means that 70% of all advertising pieces received at least some attention from the household with only 30% of pieces being discarded without being read. The share of advertising mail that was discarded in 2024 is not much different from the shares in 2014 and 2019.

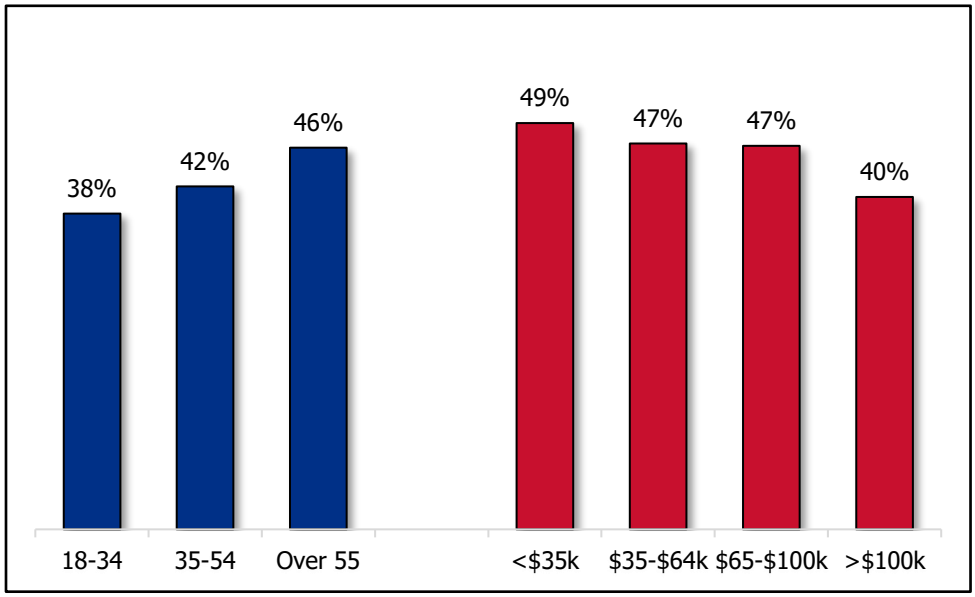
Figure 5.7: Advertising Mail Reading Trends



Source: *HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Advertising. Mail pieces for which reading treatment was not provided are excluded.*

Figure 5.8 illustrates how household demographics can influence advertising reading rates. On the left side of the chart we see that the age of the household head is strongly tied to the percentage of advertising mail pieces that are read. On the right side of the chart, we see that low-income households reported reading a larger share of advertising than higher income earners. This was likely related to a previous finding that higher income households tend to receive more advertising mail (see Figure 5.2). With more ads received, higher income households may be less likely to read any individual piece. According to the chart, households earning more than $100,000 read only 40% of their ad mail, compared to around 49% for households with incomes less than $35,000.

Figure 5.8: Advertising Mail Reading Rates by Household Demographics



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes First-Class Advertising and Marketing Mail.

Effectiveness of Advertising Mail

Ultimately, advertisers send direct mail because it works—household members read and respond to it. Table 5.4 shows the percentage of advertising mail pieces for which the household is considering responding to the advertising. Households reported that they were considering responding to 11% of First-Class advertising pieces, 8% of Commercial Marketing Mail pieces, and 13% of Nonprofit Marketing Mail pieces. Overall, households reported that they were considering responding to 9% of the advertising mail received.

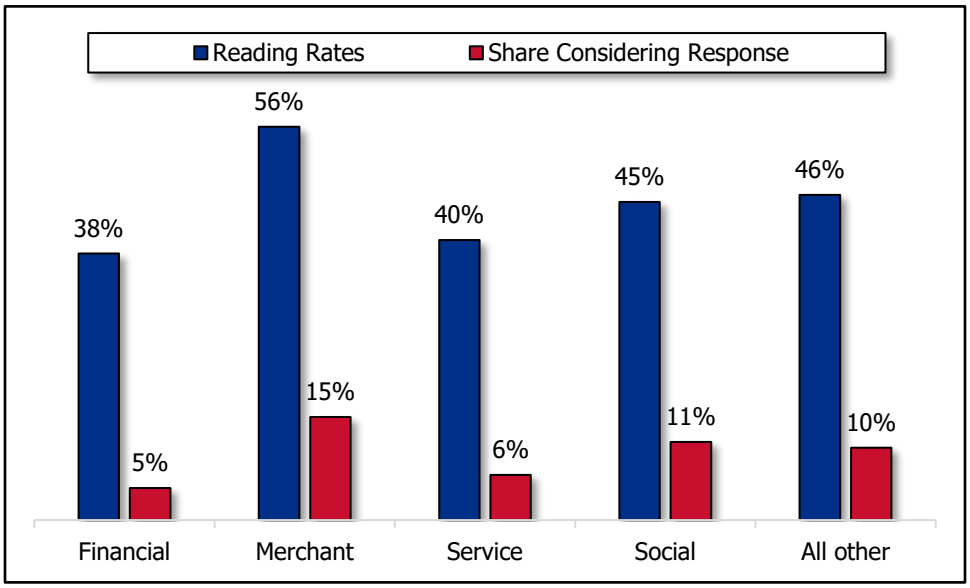
Table 5.4: Households Considering a Response to Advertising Mail Piece
(Percentage of Pieces)

Ad type	Share
First-Class	11%
Commercial Marketing	8%
Nonprofit Marketing	13%
All Advertising	9%

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. First-Class includes ad only and ad enclosed.

Figure 5.9 shows reading and response rates for advertising mail by the industry of sender. The financial industry had both the lowest reading and response rate due to the large number of credit card solicitations that it sends. Merchants had both the highest reading rate and response rate. A good portion of merchant advertising mail is catalogs.

Figure 5.9: Advertising Mail Reading and Response Rates by Sender Industry



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes First-Class Advertising and Marketing Mail.

Table 5.5 illustrates how the existence of a past business relationship between the mailer and the recipient can impact the effectiveness of advertising mail. Advertising mail sent to a recipient with whom the business had a prior relationship (e.g.: a previous or existing customer) was more than twice as likely to be read (60% of pieces vs. 26%) than mail sent when there is no past business relationship. The difference in response rates was even greater, with mail sent to existing customers registering a 15% response rate compared to just 2% for prospecting ad mail. Yet, despite the lower reading and response rates for mail sent to prospects, the fact that some of this mail is read and responded is crucial to business efforts to expand their customer base.

Table 5.5: Reading and Response Rates to Marketing Mail Advertising by Past Relationship
(Percentage of Pieces)

Past Business Relationship with Recipient	Reading Rate	Share considering Response
Existing Customers	60%	15%
Prospects	26%	2%
All Recipients	**44%**	**9%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Mail pieces for which reading or response treatment were not provided are excluded.

As illustrated earlier in Figure 5.3, higher income households received more advertising mail than low-income households. Table 5.6 combines the yearly volume of advertising mail received by each income group with the respective response rates reported in Table 5.5. The result is the average number of potential responses per year for each income level.

As the chart illustrates, households with incomes greater than $100,000 have a lower response rate than lower income households, stating that they are considering a response to 8% of the advertising pieces received. However, these households also receive the most advertising pieces. Consequently, despite their lower response rate, the total number of potential responses of 40 per year is higher than for the other income groups.

Households considering a response does not always lead to actual responses, but the data presented in Table 5.5 and Figure 5.9 help explain why direct mail is a popular choice for advertisers in the U.S.

Table 5.6: Yearly Number of Potential Responses by Income

Household Income	Ad pieces Received per household	Share Considering Response	Total Potential Responses per Household
Less than $35,000	252.6	10%	24.1
$35,000–$64,999	371.3	10%	36.9
$65,000–$99,999	377.5	10%	36.5
$100,000 or More	491.2	8%	40.4
All Households	**394.2**	**9%**	**35.3**

Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024. Includes Marketing Mail and First-Class Mail advertising.

Chapter 6: Periodicals

Introduction

This chapter examines the volumes and types of periodicals received by households in 2024, with comparisons to 2019 and 2014. Periodical mail consists of newspapers, magazines, and newsletters sent to households, typically as part of a subscription. This chapter analyzes only periodicals delivered by the Postal Service to households. Newspapers or magazines delivered by a local carrier or purchased at a newsstand or store are not included in Household Diary Study data. Additionally, periodicals examined here are only a portion of the total volume, as some periodicals are received by non- households, such as doctors' offices and other businesses. Periodicals represented about 3% of all household mail in 2024.

Household Periodicals

Periodicals mail volume has been in decline for more than two decades as print circulation has been replaced with online publications and the availability of information on the internet. As Table 6.1 illustrates, the volume of periodicals has continued to fall over the last 10 years, dropping from 43.3 pieces per household in 2014 to 19.9 pieces per household in 2024.

Table 6.1: Postal Service Periodical Type by Year
(Pieces per Household per Year)

Periodical Type	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014-2024	% change 2019-2024
Magazines	34.3	23.6	12.4	-64%	-48%
Newspapers	6.5	5.6	6.1	-6%	8%
Newsletters	1.7	2.4	1.1	-39%	-55%
Unclassified	0.8	0.8	0.4	-56%	-58%
Total Periodicals	**43.3**	**32.4**	**19.9**	**-54%**	**-39%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Totals may not sum due to rounding. Does not include "Free-Not Ordered by Household Member."

In 2024, households received an average of 12.4 magazines, 48% less than 2019 and 64% less than in 2014. Despite these declines, magazines still account for 62% of all periodicals received via the Postal Service.

Households received an average of 6.1 newspapers per year in 2024, 31% of all periodicals received. The volume of newspapers has been relatively stable when compared with 2014 and 2019. The largest decline in newspaper circulation occurred in the early part of the 2000s.

Newsletters represented about 6% of all periodicals received in 2024, with an average of about 1 per year. Printed newsletters are particularly vulnerable to digital publications, evidenced by the 55% drop in volume since 2019.

As Table 6.2 highlights, the low per household volumes of Periodicals is because only 22% of households reported receiving periodicals during their Household Diary week in 2024, down from 40% in 2014. However, for households that do receive Periodicals, volume has not changed much, falling from 108 pieces in 2014 to 90 pieces in 2024.

Table 6.2: Households that Receive Periodicals

	2014	2019	2024
Share of Households that Receive any Periodicals	40%	33%	22%
Annual Volume per Household that Receives Periodicals	108.3	97.6	90.4

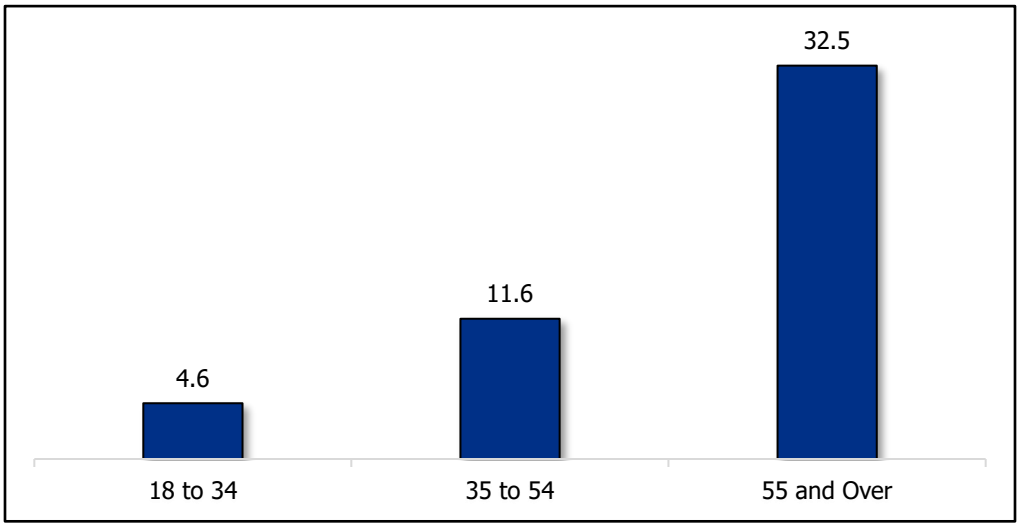
Source: HDS Diary Sample.

Periodicals Mail and Household Demographics

Figure 6.1 shows that Periodicals Mail is highly correlated with age. Households in which the household head is 55 years old or older received an average of 32.5 periodicals per year, three times as many as the 35 to 54 age group (11.6) and seven times as many as the 18 to 34 age group (4.6).

Figure 6.1: Periodicals Received by Age of Household Head

(Pieces per Household per Year)



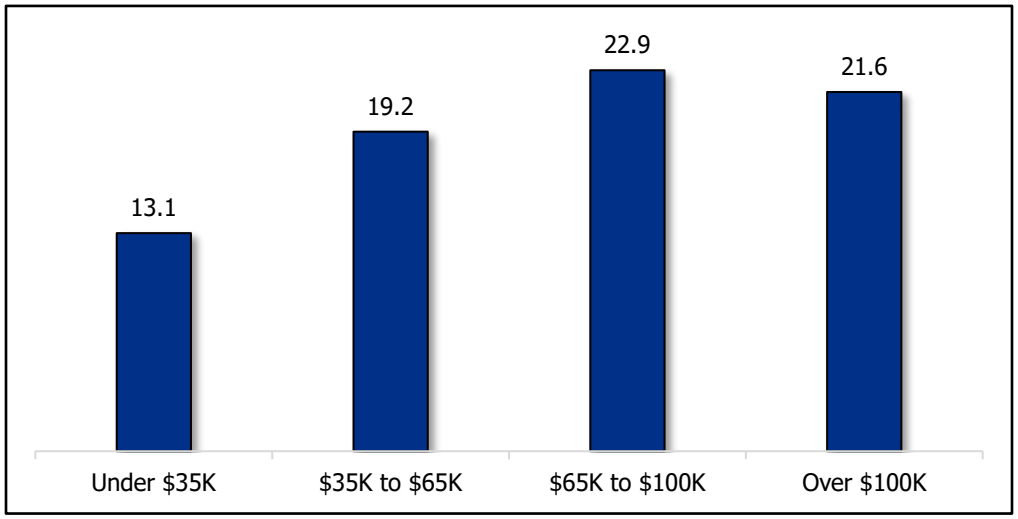
Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Heads of households 55 and over received seven times more periodicals than heads under 35

In Figure 6.2 we see that the number of periodicals received was the lowest among households earning less than $35,000 per year. Beyond that income level, however, volume was not much correlated with income as the next three income groups all received about 20 periodicals per year, with the highest income ($100,000+) group receiving slightly less volume than households with incomes between $65,000 and $100,000.

Figure 6.2: Periodicals Received by Household Income

(Pieces per Household per Year)

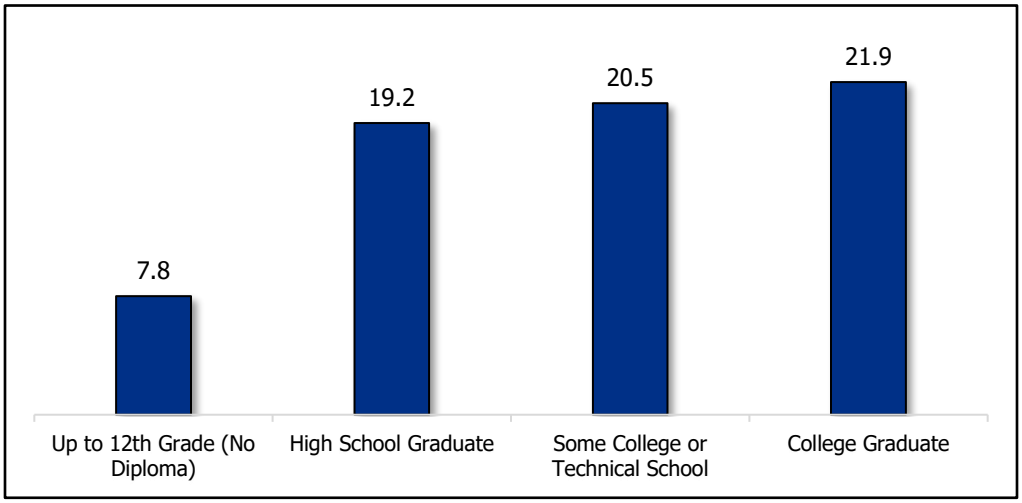


Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

The relationship between Periodicals Mail and education is similar to that of income, with only the lowest level category receiving notably different volume from all the other categories, as seen in Figure 6.3. Households headed by someone without a high school degree received an average of 7.8 periodicals per year, compared to about 20 per year for households with higher levels of education. There appears to be some positive impact on volume from greater education – households headed by a college graduate received 14% more periodicals than those with only a high school degree. The correlation between education and income probably explains the similar relationships shown in Figures 6.2 and 6.3. Moreover, since Periodicals are reading material, they may be more appealing to higher education households.

Figure 6.3: Periodicals Received by Education of Household Head

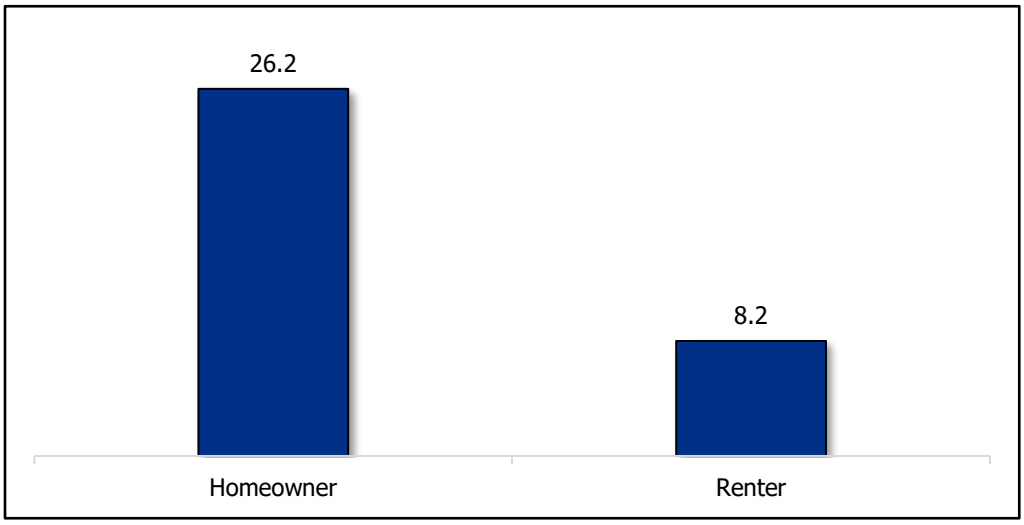
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Figure 6.4 illustrates the large difference in the number of periodicals received by homeowners and renters. Households of homeowners received over 3 times as many periodicals, an average of 26.2 per year, compared to renters who received an average of 8.2 per year.

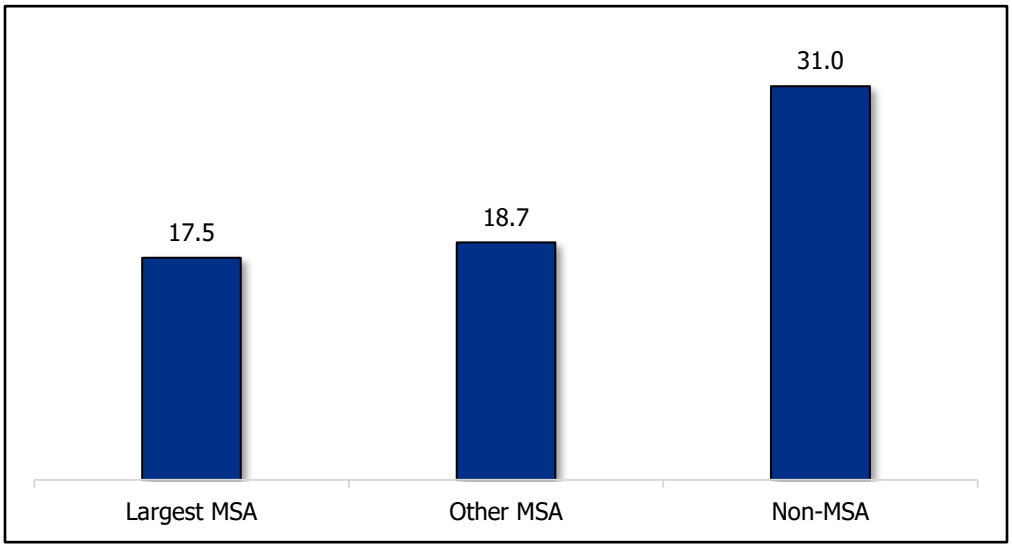
Figure 6.4: Periodicals Received by Homeownership
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

An interesting finding from Figure 6.5 is that households living outside of an MSA received about 70% more periodicals per household than were received by households living in more urban areas. This is likely because in these areas postal delivery of periodicals is more common than delivery from private companies that choose not to provide service to less densely populated communities.

Figure 6.5: Periodicals Received by MSA Classification
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Tables 6.3 and 6.4 look at how age and metropolitan location have impacted Periodicals Mail over the past ten years. Table 6.3 shows that while mail volumes of periodicals have declined across all age groups, the declines have been much greater among younger households. From 2014 to 2024, Periodicals to households aged 18 to 34 fell from 23.5 per year to 4.6 per year, an 80% decline. Among households headed by someone 55 and over, the decline – though still substantial – was 46%.

Table 6.3: Periodicals Received by Age of Household Head

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Age of Household Head	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014-2024	% change 2019-2024
18 to 34	23.5	12.2	4.6	-80%	-62%
35 to 54	36.6	23.5	11.6	-68%	-51%
55 and Over	59.9	47.9	32.5	-46%	-32%
All Households	**43.3**	**32.4**	**19.9**	**-54%**	**-39%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample.

Table 6.4 shows that the largest declines in Periodicals Mail have occurred in more urban areas. From 2014 to 2024, households living in the largest MSAs saw their volume of periodicals fall by 58%. Meanwhile, households living outside an MSA had volumes fall by 42%.

Table 6.4: Periodicals Received by MSA Classification

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Metro Area Classification	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014-2024	% change 2019-2024
Largest MSA	41.3	29.0	17.5	-58%	-40%
Other MSA	42.9	32.8	18.7	-56%	-43%
Non-MSA	53.6	45.5	31.0	-42%	-32%
All Households	**43.3**	**32.4**	**19.9**	**-54%**	**-39%**

Source: HDS Diary Sample.

Chapter 7: Packages

Introduction

This chapter discusses packages received and sent by households. Packages can be mailed via the U.S. Postal Service using a variety of products and at rates that are based on weight, shape, and other relevant factors. Packages received and sent represented about 8% of total household mail in 2024.

The Package Market

The package delivery market is an important segment of the economy. There are three major components of the package market:

- Overnight,
- Two- and three-day, and
- Ground.

The U.S. Postal Service provides services in all segments: Priority Mail Express in the overnight segment, Priority in the two- and three-day segment, and Ground Advantage and Parcel Select are in the ground segment. Other smaller package categories in the ground segment include Media Mail and Bound Printed Matter.

Postal Service Package Volume

Compared to other types of mail, such as letters, bills, or advertising materials, most households do not receive packages regularly, on a daily or weekly basis, as they do with the mail. Consequently, the number of packages captured in the Household Diary Study survey is usually relatively small. For this reason, packages volumes are aggregated across the different USPS categories to provide a larger sample for analysis.

Table 7.1 displays package volumes for 2014, 2019, and 2024. The key result is that, unlike other types of mail, USPS package volumes received by households have increased over the past ten years, nearly doubling from 25 pieces in 2014 to almost 50 in 2024. The increase in packages received is a direct result of the rapid growth in online shopping over this period. Packages received increased over the past five years as the positive impact of increased e-commerce more than offset the negative impact of the pandemic recession.

Households receive far more packages than they send. Packages sent by households grew from 2019 to 2024, rising 34%. Packages sent, however, were slightly lower in 2024 than they were in 2014. Combining packages received and sent and adjusting for the fact that household-to-household packages are included in both the received and sent totals, total household package volume increased 83% from 2014 to 2024 and 37% from 2019 to 2024.

Table 7.1: Total Postal Service Package Volumes

(Pieces per household per Year)

	2014	2019	2024	% change 2014–2024	% change 2019–2024
Received	25.2	35.7	48.5	92%	36%
Sent	5.2	3.4	4.6	-11%	34%
Total	28.3	37.7	51.8	83%	37%

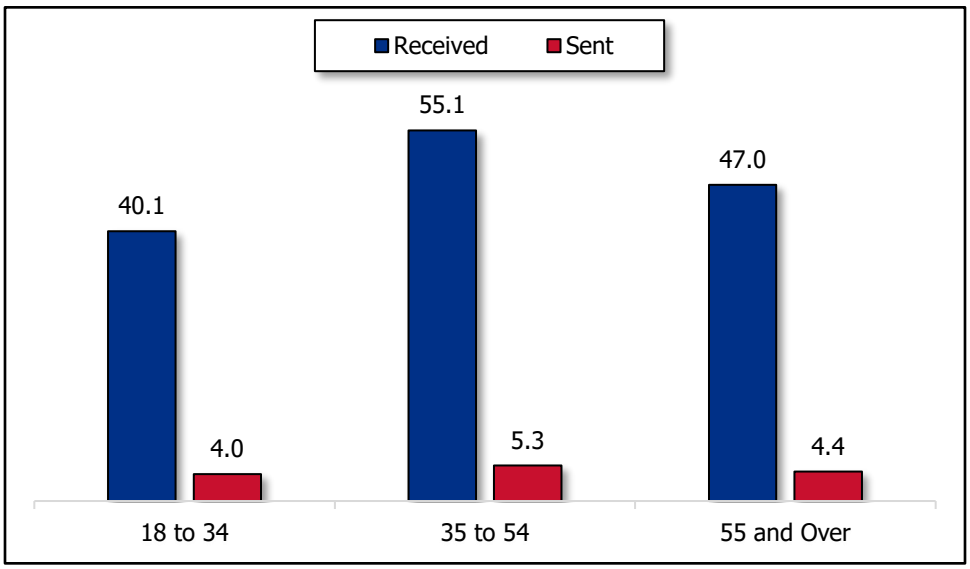
Source: HDS Diary Sample. Note: Total is adjusted for double count of packages sent and received between households.

Packages and Household Characteristics

The age of the head of households has a much smaller impact on package volumes than it does on other types of mail. As shown in Figure 7.1, heads of households between 35 and 54 years of age receive and send more packages than either their younger or older counterparts, but differences across age groups are not large. While older households typically have higher incomes than younger households, younger households are more familiar with using the internet for online shopping.

Figure 7.1: Package Volumes by Age of Household Head

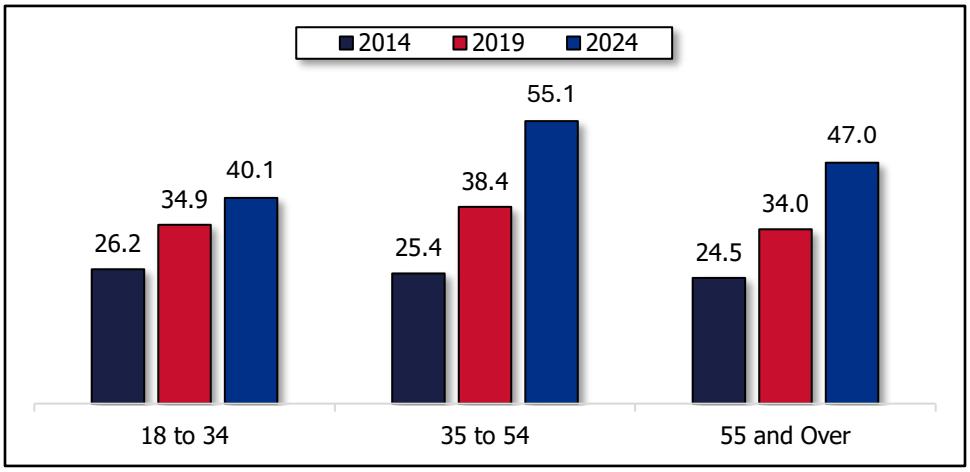
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample FY 2024.

However, as shown in Figure 7.2, the increase in packages received was driven by greater growth among older households. In 2014, households received about 25 packages per year across all three age groups. By 2024, packages received increased 53% among households headed by someone aged 18 to 34, 117% among households headed by someone aged 35 to 54, and 92% among households headed by someone 55 or older.

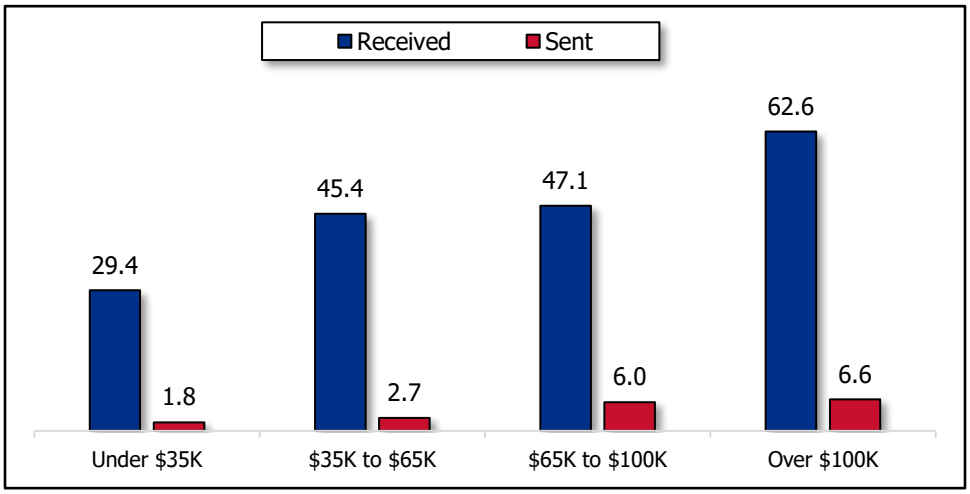
Figure 7.2: Packages Received by Age of Household Head
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample.

Since package volumes are directly related to purchases it is not surprising that household income is a key factor affecting volumes. As Figure 7.3 illustrates, in 2024, households with incomes over $100,000 received an average of 63 packages per year, more than double the 29 packages received on average by households earning less than $35,000. Packages sent were even more strongly tied to income, with the two highest income groups sending an average of six or more packages per year, while the lowest two income groups sent less than three. Put another way, the highest income group sent more than three times as many packages as the lowest income group.

Figure 7.3: Package Volumes by Household Income
(Pieces per Household per Year)

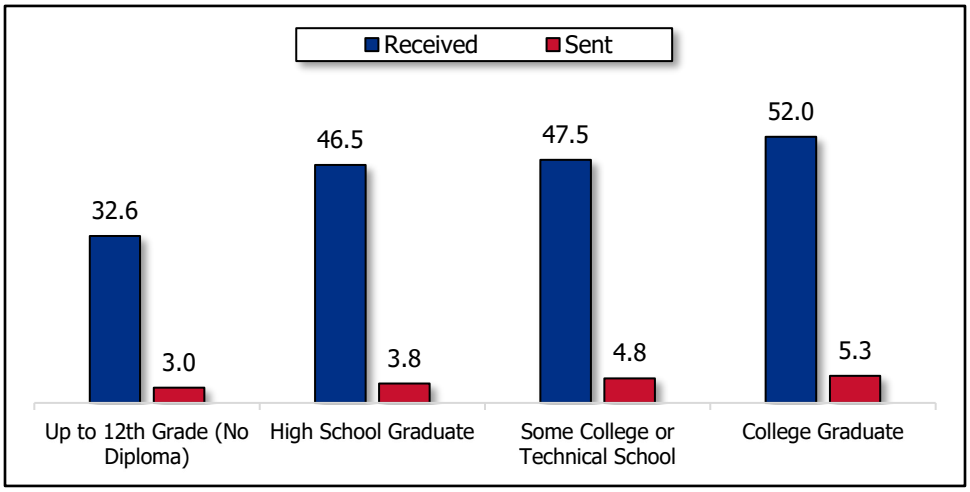


Source: HDS Diary Sample FY 2024.

Figure 7.4 illustrates the impact of education on the number of packages received and sent by households. The number of packages received and sent per household increased as the level of education increased.

Figure 7.4: Package Volumes by Education of Household Head

(Pieces per Household per Year)

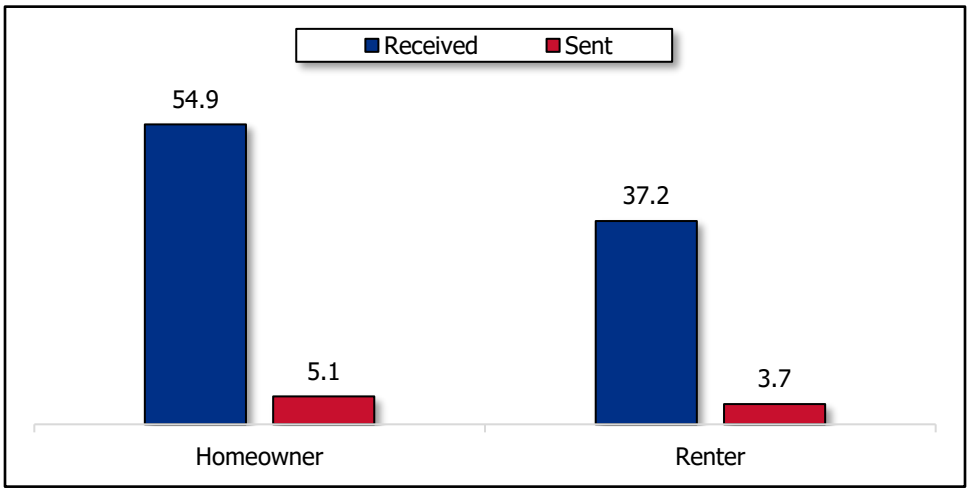


Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Homeowners and renters had noticeable differences in the number of packages received and sent as shown in Figure 7.5. Homeowners received 48% more packages and sent 38% more packages than renters.

Figure 7.5: Package Volumes by Homeownership

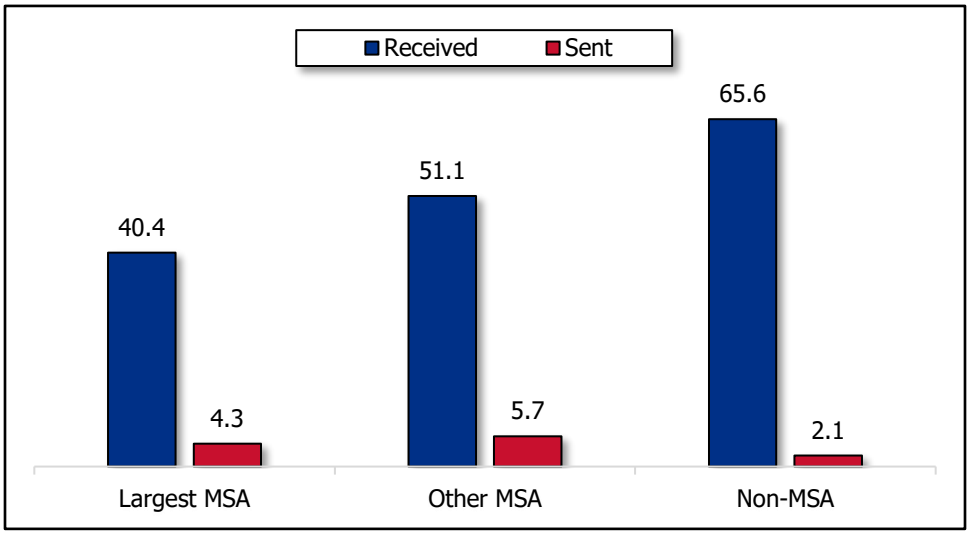
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

There were significant differences in the number of packages received and sent depending on the population density of where the household is located. Figure 7.6 shows that households in less densely populated areas (non-MSA) received more USPS delivered packages than households in more densely populated MSAs. The non-MSA households received an average of 62% more packages than households living in one of the 30 largest MSAs, and 28% more packages than households living in other MSAs. The fact that USPS competitors do not always provide as many delivery services to less densely populated areas is probably a key reason explaining these differences. On the other hand, households living outside of an MSA sent fewer packages than households living in an MSA.

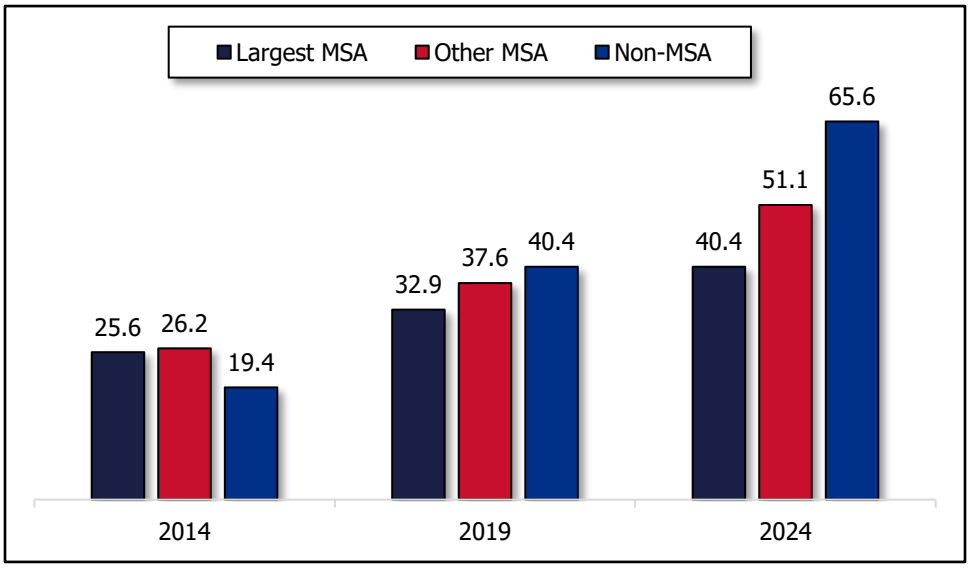
Figure 7.6: Package Volumes by MSA Classification
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample, FY 2024.

Figure 7.7 looks at changes in packages received over the past ten years by metro classification. The key finding is that the non-metro areas saw the most substantial increase in package volumes per household over the last decade. In 2014, households in metro areas received about 26 packages per year while those living outside of metropolitan areas received fewer than 20. By 2024, this relationship had been reversed, with households in non-metro areas receiving an average of 66 packages per year, far more than received by households living in metropolitan areas.

Figure 7.7: Packages Received by MSA Classification
(Pieces per Household per Year)



Source: HDS Diary Sample

Reasons for using the Postal Service to Send Packages

The HDS recruitment survey asks households which delivery company they prefer to use, or most often use, to send packages. For the 76% of households for which the USPS was their selected delivery company, respondents were also asked why they prefer the USPS over its competitors. Results are shown in Table 7.2. Note that respondents were allowed to choose multiple reasons.

Two-thirds of households who prefer the USPS to send packages said that "convenient location" was one of the main reasons for doing so. More than half said it was because USPS service was cheaper than its competitors. Other key reasons commonly stated were aspects of USPS service – reliability, online tracking, more efficient, and faster delivery.

Table 7.2: Reasons for Using the USPS to Send Packages

Reason	Percent of Households
Convenient Location	66%
Cheaper	51%
More reliable/seems safer	32%
Online tracking	30%
The service is better/more efficient/friendly	28%
Faster delivery	17%

Source: HDS Recruitment Sample, FY 2024. Note: Respondents may choose multiple answers.

Appendix A: Annual Trends

Table A-1: First-Class Mail Received by Type

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Total Correspondence	124.7	118.2	120.6	119.4	117.5	109.9	109.2	110.6	105.4	97.5	93.2
Total Personal	29.2	25.1	25.6	24.7	25.3	21.9	21.9	24.8	21.9	18.2	16.6
Greeting Cards	20.7	17.4	18.2	17.9	19.6	15.4	15.7	18.8	16.4	13.9	13.1
Other Personal	8.5	7.8	7.4	6.9	5.7	6.5	6.2	6.0	5.5	4.3	3.5
Total Social	9.6	8.8	8.8	8.2	7.9	7.9	7.8	6.6	5.8	5.7	4.8
Total Business/Government	85.9	84.3	86.2	86.5	84.2	80.0	79.5	79.2	77.6	73.5	71.7
Notice/ Announcement/ Business Invitation	39.9	40.2	40.2	40.0	37.3	35.6	34.6	33.5	32.5	35.0	36.7
Insurance	20.5	18.5	18.7	19.9	20.1	19.9	17.6	17.4	16.9	14.9	12.1
Other Bus/Gov	25.5	25.6	27.3	26.6	26.9	24.5	27.3	28.3	28.3	23.6	22.8
Total Transactions	173.8	166.9	162.4	151.9	148.0	134.7	130.2	121.6	114.1	113.2	99.9
Bills	84.9	82.2	78.8	72.1	68.9	63.2	58.3	53.9	50.8	49.3	45.2
Financial Statements	36.6	32.7	31.9	31.5	30.7	29.0	30.1	27.5	26.5	27.2	21.1
Credit Card Statement/Bill	30.3	29.2	30.3	27.8	29.2	26.0	24.1	21.5	19.1	19.9	18.6
Other Transactions	22.0	22.7	21.3	20.5	19.2	16.5	17.8	18.7	17.7	16.9	15.0
Advertising (Ads Only)	31.9	28.9	30.3	29.8	27.7	30.9	27.0	28.4	30.5	24.7	23.0
Other First-Class Mail Received*	17.8	15.3	15.7	14.9	13.5	13.4	11.7	10.9	8.2	9.0	5.6
Total First-Class Mail Received	348.2	329.3	329.0	316.1	306.7	288.8	278.1	271.4	258.2	244.4	221.7

*Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. *Other First-Class Mail received includes CDs, DVDs and pieces where purpose was not reported.*

Table A-2: First-Class Mail Received by Type

(Percentage of Total First-Class Mail Received)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Total Correspondence	36%	36%	37%	38%	38%	38%	39%	41%	41%	40%	42%
Total Personal	8%	8%	8%	8%	8%	8%	8%	9%	8%	7%	8%
Greeting Cards	6%	5%	6%	6%	6%	5%	6%	7%	6%	6%	6%
Other Personal	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%
Total Social	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	2%	2%	2%	2%
Total Business/Government	25%	26%	26%	27%	27%	28%	29%	29%	30%	30%	32%
Notice/ Announcement/ Business Invitation	11%	12%	12%	13%	12%	12%	12%	12%	13%	14%	17%
Insurance	6%	6%	6%	6%	7%	7%	6%	6%	7%	6%	5%
Other Bus/Gov	7%	8%	8%	8%	9%	8%	10%	10%	11%	10%	10%
Total Transactions	50%	51%	49%	48%	48%	47%	47%	45%	44%	46%	45%
Bills	24%	25%	24%	23%	22%	22%	21%	20%	20%	20%	20%
Financial Statements	11%	10%	10%	10%	10%	10%	11%	10%	10%	11%	10%
Credit Card Statement/Bill	9%	9%	9%	9%	10%	9%	9%	8%	7%	8%	8%
Other	6%	7%	6%	6%	6%	6%	6%	7%	7%	7%	7%
Advertising (Ads Only)	9%	9%	9%	9%	9%	11%	10%	10%	12%	10%	10%
Other First-Class Mail Received*	5%	5%	5%	5%	4%	5%	4%	4%	3%	4%	3%
Total First-Class Received	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%

*Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. *Other First-Class Mail Sent includes CDs, DVDs, and pieces where purpose was not reported.*

Table A-3: First-Class Mail Sent by Type

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Total Correspondence	35.5	36.2	31.8	29.3	27.6	26.0	26.8	27.5	24.9	16.7	14.9
Total Personal	25.2	25.9	22.4	20.5	20.5	18.4	19.4	19.8	18.0	11.3	10.8
Greeting Cards	17.8	17.3	16.7	15.2	15.2	13.4	14.0	14.8	13.0	8.0	9.0
Other Personal	7.3	8.6	5.7	5.3	5.3	4.9	5.4	5.1	5.0	3.3	1.8
Total Social	1.7	1.2	1.2	0.9	1.0	1.2	1.4	1.6	0.8	0.4	0.6
Total Business/Government	8.7	9.0	8.2	7.9	6.0	6.5	6.0	6.0	6.1	4.9	3.4
Total Transactions	41.3	38.2	34.1	30.7	27.5	24.9	22.9	21.5	18.2	15.4	11.4
Bill Payments	36.7	34.3	30.3	27.0	24.1	21.8	19.3	18.4	15.0	12.8	8.8
Other Transaction Mail	4.7	3.9	3.8	3.6	3.3	3.1	3.7	3.1	3.2	2.6	2.6
Other First-Class Mail Sent*	3.5	2.8	2.1	2.4	2.4	1.3	1.2	1.3	0.8	1.3	0.4
Total First-Class Mail Sent	80.3	77.2	68.0	62.3	57.5	52.2	50.9	50.3	43.9	33.4	26.6

*Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. *Other First-Class Mail Sent includes CDs, DVDs, and pieces where purpose was not reported.*

Table A-4: First-Class Mail Sent by Type

(Percentage of Total First-Class Mail Sent)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Total Correspondence	44%	47%	47%	47%	48%	50%	53%	55%	57%	50%	56%
Total Personal	31%	34%	33%	33%	36%	35%	38%	39%	41%	34%	41%
Greeting Cards	22%	22%	25%	24%	26%	26%	28%	29%	30%	24%	34%
Other Personal	9%	11%	8%	8%	9%	9%	11%	10%	11%	10%	7%
Total Social	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	3%	3%	2%	1%	2%
Total Business/Government	11%	12%	12%	13%	10%	12%	12%	12%	14%	15%	13%
Total Transactions	51%	50%	50%	49%	48%	48%	45%	43%	41%	46%	43%
Bill Payments	46%	44%	45%	43%	42%	42%	38%	37%	34%	38%	33%
Other Transaction Mail	6%	5%	6%	6%	6%	6%	7%	6%	7%	8%	10%
Other First-Class Mail Sent [1]	4%	4%	3%	4%	4%	3%	2%	3%	2%	4%	1%
Total First-Class Mail Sent	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%

*Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. *Other First-Class Mail Sent includes CDs, DVDs, and pieces where purpose was not reported.*

Table A-5: Bills and Statements Received

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Payee	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Total Financial	87.5	82.5	82.0	77.3	75.5	69.2	67.8	60.5	57.1	58.1	49.9
Credit Card	30.3	29.2	30.3	28.0	29.1	26.1	24.1	21.3	19.5	19.9	18.7
Bank, S&L, Credit Union	29.0	25.8	24.3	23.1	22.0	20.2	19.6	18.0	16.9	16.7	14.1
Insurance Company[1]	14.0	13.7	13.3	13.4	11.7	10.6	11.2	10.1	10.1	9.3	8.4
Other Financial	14.2	13.7	14.0	12.8	12.7	12.2	12.9	11.1	10.6	12.2	8.8
Total Merchants	4.0	4.0	3.3	3.2	3.0	2.2	1.6	2.2	1.4	1.0	1.3
Total Service	54.7	51.8	51.0	46.8	45.8	42.5	39.2	35.0	32.4	32.6	28.8
Utility Company	35.6	34.3	32.6	31.8	29.7	27.5	26.0	21.4	19.4	18.7	17.0
Medical and Other Professional	16.4	14.7	15.4	12.5	13.3	12.5	10.1	11.3	11.0	11.7	9.9
Other Service	2.7	2.8	3.0	2.5	2.9	2.5	3.1	2.4	2.0	2.2	2.0
Government	3.8	4.1	3.1	3.0	3.2	3.2	2.9	3.8	4.2	3.7	3.6
Social	1.1	1.0	1.1	0.8	0.8	0.6	0.6	0.6	0.6	0.4	0.6
Other/Don't Know/Refused	0.7	0.8	0.5	0.4	0.4	0.5	0.4	0.7	0.5	0.6	0.7
Total Bills and Statements	151.8	144.2	141.1	131.5	128.8	118.2	112.5	102.9	96.3	96.4	84.9

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A–6: Bills Paid by Method

(Percentage of Pieces)

Method	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Mail	33%	31%	27%	30%	27%	23%	21%	19%	17%	15%	13%
In Person	4%	4%	4%	4%	4%	3%	3%	2%	2%	2%	2%
Non-electronic	38%	35%	31%	34%	31%	27%	24%	21%	19%	18%	15%
Computer	35%	35%	34%	31%	31%	32%	30%	31%	30%	28%	28%
Mobile	3%	4%	7%	8%	10%	12%	14%	14%	17%	19%	20%
Other Internet	3%	6%	5%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	4%	4%	4%
By Internet	41%	44%	46%	43%	44%	48%	48%	49%	50%	51%	51%
Phone	3%	3%	3%	4%	4%	4%	3%	3%	3%	3%	2%
Automatic Deduction or Debit Charge	14%	14%	15%	15%	15%	16%	18%	20%	19%	19%	20%
Automatic Credit Charge	4%	4%	5%	5%	6%	6%	7%	8%	9%	10%	10%
Electronic (excluding Internet)	21%	21%	23%	24%	25%	26%	28%	30%	30%	31%	33%
Electronic (including Internet)	62%	65%	69%	66%	69%	73%	76%	79%	81%	82%	85%

Source: HDS Recruitment Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A–7: Method of Paying Bills

(Percentage of Households)

Method	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Mail	71%	69%	68%	63%	59%	56%	55%	51%	51%	47%	43%
In Person	24%	25%	25%	22%	23%	20%	18%	14%	16%	17%	18%
Computer	61%	61%	63%	56%	55%	58%	57%	59%	63%	60%	59%
Mobile	11%	16%	23%	23%	26%	31%	36%	36%	43%	48%	51%
Other Internet	7%	12%	12%	8%	8%	9%	9%	9%	12%	11%	11%
By Internet	63%	64%	67%	66%	68%	72%	75%	77%	82%	83%	83%
Phone	16%	17%	19%	18%	18%	16%	16%	14%	15%	16%	15%
Automatic Deduction or Debit Charge	53%	53%	61%	52%	54%	57%	60%	62%	67%	67%	70%
Automatic Credit Charge	20%	21%	27%	22%	25%	27%	30%	32%	40%	41%	43%
Electronic (excluding Internet)	63%	65%	72%	65%	67%	68%	72%	74%	78%	78%	81%
Electronic (including Internet)	81%	81%	85%	85%	86%	88%	90%	92%	94%	95%	95%

Source: HDS Recruitment Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A–8: Payments by Payee Type

(Pieces per Household per Year)

Payee	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Total Financial	14.4	14.2	12.9	11.2	10.1	9.0	8.0	7.1	5.7	4.6	3.4
Credit Card	7.3	6.9	6.6	5.8	5.3	4.9	4.2	3.8	3.4	2.9	1.7
Bank, S&L, Credit Union	2.2	2.6	2.1	1.5	1.5	1.3	0.9	1.0	0.7	0.5	0.6
Insurance Company[1]	3.4	2.9	2.9	2.4	2.3	2.0	1.9	1.7	1.2	0.8	0.7
Other Financial	1.6	1.8	1.3	1.5	0.9	0.8	1.0	0.6	0.4	0.4	0.3
Total Merchants	2.5	2.0	2.0	1.9	1.3	1.3	1.2	1.2	0.8	0.6	0.6
Total Service	17.3	15.9	13.5	12.3	11.3	9.8	8.7	8.3	7.1	6.5	3.9
Utility Company	11.2	10.7	8.8	8.4	7.1	6.7	5.8	5.3	4.0	3.8	2.2
Medical and Other Professional	4.5	3.8	3.4	2.6	2.8	1.8	1.8	1.9	1.9	1.7	0.8
Other Service	1.6	1.4	1.4	1.3	1.3	1.3	1.1	1.1	1.2	1.0	0.8
Government	1.1	1.0	0.9	0.9	0.7	0.8	0.6	0.8	0.7	0.5	0.5
Social	0.5	0.5	0.4	0.5	0.4	0.5	0.3	0.4	0.3	0.2	0.2
Other/Don't Know/Refused	0.8	0.7	0.6	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.4	0.6	0.4	0.4	0.3
Total Payments Sent	36.7	34.3	30.3	27.0	24.1	21.8	19.3	18.4	15.0	12.8	8.8

Source: HDS Recruitment Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A–9: Share of Households by Number of Purchases Made over the Internet over the Past Month

(Percent of Households)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
All Households											
None	37%	36%	35%	30%	24%	19%	16%	13%	10%	12%	12%
1	8%	8%	8%	6%	6%	6%	4%	3%	3%	3%	4%
2	11%	11%	10%	10%	9%	9%	8%	6%	7%	7%	7%
3 - 5	24%	24%	24%	29%	27%	28%	27%	24%	26%	29%	28%
6 - 10	12%	14%	14%	16%	20%	21%	23%	26%	27%	27%	28%
More than 10	7%	8%	9%	9%	14%	16%	22%	28%	26%	22%	22%
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%
Households that Made 1+ purchases											
1	13%	12%	12%	9%	8%	8%	5%	3%	4%	4%	4%
2	18%	17%	16%	14%	12%	12%	9%	7%	8%	8%	8%
3 - 5	39%	38%	36%	42%	36%	35%	32%	28%	29%	33%	31%
6 - 10	19%	21%	21%	23%	26%	26%	28%	29%	30%	31%	31%
More than 10	11%	12%	14%	13%	18%	20%	26%	32%	29%	25%	25%
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%

Source: HDS Recruitment Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. Notes: Households that did not respond to this question are excluded from this analysis.

Table A-10: Advertising by Type

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
First-Class Mail Advertising	73.3	66.8	65.7	62.2	59.3	58.3	48.7	51.6	51.9	40.6	36.8
Advertising-Only	31.9	28.9	30.3	29.8	27.7	30.9	27.0	28.4	30.5	24.7	23.0
Secondary Advertising	41.5	37.9	35.4	32.4	31.6	27.4	21.7	23.3	21.4	15.9	13.9
Marketing Mail Advertising	580.9	573.4	570.0	549.6	532.4	512.5	436.0	453.5	448.9	405.3	357.4
Regular	479.7	472.7	479.3	456.3	439.6	420.3	346.6	358.9	357.5	319.8	282.3
Nonprofit	101.2	100.7	90.7	93.3	92.9	92.2	89.4	94.6	91.4	85.5	75.1
Other	19.3	15.2	18.0	19.2	17.1	17.0	15.2	15.7	17.8	15.5	15.8
Unsolicited Periodicals	10.4	9.1	9.6	11.3	9.4	9.1	7.7	9.4	8.4	8.6	8.3
Unaddressed Mail	8.9	6.1	8.4	7.9	7.7	7.9	7.4	6.3	9.4	6.9	7.4
Total Advertising	673.5	655.4	653.8	631.0	608.9	587.8	500.0	520.8	518.6	461.3	409.9

Source: HDS Recruitment Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A-11: First-Class and Marketing Mail Advertising by Sender Type

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
First-Class Ads*											
Financial	27.7	26.8	25.5	25.2	24.4	23.9	21.0	22.0	23.4	15.7	13.8
Merchants	14.6	12.8	11.9	11.1	11.1	10.8	8.7	8.9	8.8	6.6	7.2
Services	23.9	21.3	21.7	20.5	17.8	17.4	13.5	14.0	14.5	12.9	10.8
Manufacturers	1.1	1.2	1.4	1.2	0.9	1.3	1.1	1.8	1.2	1.3	1.0
Government	1.9	1.2	1.4	1.2	1.4	1.3	1.3	1.7	1.3	1.4	1.2
Social	3.8	3.4	3.4	2.8	3.5	3.4	2.9	3.0	2.5	2.4	2.4
Don't know/Rather not say	0.2	0.1	0.3	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.3	0.2	0.2	0.3
Total	73.3	66.8	65.7	62.2	59.3	58.3	48.7	51.6	51.9	40.6	36.8
Marketing Mail Ads											
Financial	125.4	126.9	138.8	130.8	128.9	131.0	100.4	110.3	120.0	97.4	89.7
Merchants	188.2	177.6	170.8	166.8	154.2	133.7	109.5	102.6	96.7	86.0	71.2
Services	92.5	93.5	94.1	90.4	87.0	85.9	70.6	78.5	77.5	80.1	72.2
Manufacturers	7.8	9.9	10.3	9.7	8.3	9.1	6.8	9.5	8.1	6.5	5.9
Government	7.2	7.3	7.7	7.2	8.0	8.5	11.3	10.6	9.7	8.2	9.4
Social	102.3	100.1	95.3	93.7	95.7	96.7	95.2	99.0	97.8	92.3	81.0
From Multiple Organizations	53.8	55.1	49.2	48.0	46.5	44.1	39.2	38.6	36.6	31.6	24.5
Don't know/Rather not say	3.7	2.8	3.9	2.8	3.7	3.5	3.1	4.4	2.4	3.1	3.6
Total	580.9	573.4	570.0	549.6	532.4	512.5	436.0	453.5	448.9	405.3	357.4
Total First-Class and Marketing Mail Ads											
Financial	153.1	153.7	164.3	156.0	153.3	154.9	121.3	132.3	143.5	113.0	103.5
Merchants	202.8	190.5	182.7	177.9	165.3	144.6	118.3	111.5	105.5	92.6	78.4
Services	116.4	114.8	115.8	110.9	104.8	103.3	84.1	92.5	91.9	93.0	83.0
Manufacturers	9.0	11.1	11.7	10.9	9.2	10.5	7.9	11.3	9.3	7.8	6.9
Government	9.1	8.5	9.1	8.4	9.4	9.7	12.6	12.3	11.0	9.6	10.6
Social	106.1	103.5	98.7	96.5	99.3	100.1	98.1	101.9	100.4	94.8	83.4
From Multiple Organizations	53.8	55.1	49.2	48.0	46.5	44.1	39.2	38.6	36.6	31.6	24.5
Don't know/Rather not say	3.9	3.0	4.2	3.1	3.9	3.6	3.3	4.7	2.6	3.4	3.9
Total	654.2	640.2	635.7	611.8	591.8	570.8	484.8	505.1	500.8	445.9	394.2

*Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. *Includes Secondary Advertising.*

Table A-12: First-Class Advertising Ad-only and Ad-enclosed by Sender Type

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
First-Class Ads (Ad only)											
Financial	9.1	9.4	9.4	10.6	9.6	11.8	10.9	12.1	13.3	9.0	8.4
Merchants	12.0	10.0	9.1	8.5	8.8	8.9	7.3	7.3	7.3	5.6	6.1
Services	8.1	7.4	8.7	8.7	7.2	7.9	6.5	5.9	7.5	7.6	6.4
Manufacturers	1.0	0.8	1.2	1.0	0.8	1.1	1.0	1.7	1.0	1.2	0.9
Government	0.5	0.2	0.4	0.3	0.3	0.3	0.4	0.4	0.5	0.4	0.4
Social	1.1	1.0	1.2	0.7	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.9	0.8	0.9	0.7
Don't know/Rather not say	0.1	0.1	0.2	0.1	0.0	0.0	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.2
Total	31.9	28.9	30.3	29.8	27.7	30.9	27.0	28.4	30.5	24.7	23.0
First-Class Ads (Ad enclosed)											
Financial	18.6	17.4	16.1	14.6	14.8	12.1	10.1	9.9	10.1	6.7	5.4
Merchants	2.6	2.8	2.8	2.6	2.2	1.9	1.4	1.7	1.5	1.1	1.1
Services	15.8	13.8	13.0	11.8	10.6	9.4	7.0	8.0	7.0	5.2	4.4
Manufacturers	0.2	0.4	0.1	0.3	0.2	0.2	0.1	0.1	0.2	0.1	0.2
Government	1.4	1.0	1.0	0.9	1.0	1.0	0.9	1.3	0.8	1.1	0.8
Social	2.7	2.4	2.2	2.1	2.5	2.5	2.1	2.0	1.8	1.6	1.7
Don't know/Rather not say	0.2	0.1	0.1	0.2	0.2	0.1	0.1	0.2	0.1	0.1	0.1
Total	41.5	37.9	35.4	32.4	31.6	27.4	21.7	23.3	21.4	15.9	13.9
Total First-Class Ads											
Financial	27.7	26.8	25.5	25.2	24.4	23.9	21.0	22.0	23.4	15.7	13.8
Merchants	14.6	12.8	11.9	11.1	11.1	10.8	8.7	8.9	8.8	6.6	7.2
Services	23.9	21.3	21.7	20.5	17.8	17.4	13.5	14.0	14.5	12.9	10.8
Manufacturers	1.1	1.2	1.4	1.2	0.9	1.3	1.1	1.8	1.2	1.3	1.0
Government	1.9	1.2	1.4	1.2	1.4	1.3	1.3	1.7	1.3	1.4	1.2
Social	3.8	3.4	3.4	2.8	3.5	3.4	2.9	3.0	2.5	2.4	2.4
Don't know/Rather not say	0.2	0.1	0.3	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.3	0.2	0.2	0.3
Total	73.3	66.8	65.7	62.2	59.3	58.3	48.7	51.6	51.9	40.6	36.8

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A-13: Share of First-Class and Marketing Mail Advertising by Sender Type

(Percent of Pieces)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
First-Class Ads*											
Financial	38%	40%	39%	41%	41%	41%	43%	43%	45%	39%	37%
Merchants	20%	19%	18%	18%	19%	19%	18%	17%	17%	16%	20%
Services	33%	32%	33%	33%	30%	30%	28%	27%	28%	32%	29%
Manufacturers	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	3%	2%	3%	3%
Government	3%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	3%	3%	2%	3%	3%
Social	5%	5%	5%	5%	6%	6%	6%	6%	5%	6%	7%
Don't know/Rather not say	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	1%	0%	1%	1%
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%
Marketing Mail Ads											
Financial	22%	22%	24%	24%	24%	26%	23%	24%	27%	24%	25%
Merchants	32%	31%	30%	30%	29%	26%	25%	23%	22%	21%	20%
Services	16%	16%	17%	16%	16%	17%	16%	17%	17%	20%	20%
Manufacturers	1%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%
Government	1%	1%	1%	1%	2%	2%	3%	2%	2%	2%	3%
Social	18%	17%	17%	17%	18%	19%	22%	22%	22%	23%	23%
From Multiple Organizations	9%	10%	9%	9%	9%	9%	9%	9%	8%	8%	7%
Don't know/Rather not say	1%	0%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%
Total First-Class and Marketing Mail Advertising											
Financial	23%	24%	26%	26%	26%	27%	25%	26%	29%	25%	26%
Merchants	31%	30%	29%	29%	28%	25%	24%	22%	21%	21%	20%
Services	18%	18%	18%	18%	18%	18%	17%	18%	18%	21%	21%
Manufacturers	1%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%
Government	1%	1%	1%	1%	2%	2%	3%	2%	2%	2%	3%
Social	16%	16%	16%	16%	17%	18%	20%	20%	20%	21%	21%
From Multiple Organizations	8%	9%	8%	8%	8%	8%	8%	8%	7%	7%	6%
Don't know/Rather not say	1%	0%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%

*Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. *Includes Secondary Advertising.*

Table A-14: Treatment of First-Class and Marketing Mail Advertising

(Percent of Pieces)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Read by at Least one Household Member											
All First-Class and Marketing Mail Advertising	47%	47%	45%	46%	46%	45%	46%	43%	43%	43%	44%
By ad type											
FCM Ad only	55%	55%	54%	54%	54%	51%	50%	47%	45%	50%	48%
FCM Ad enclosed	50%	52%	51%	53%	52%	54%	49%	53%	54%	55%	56%
Commercial Marketing Mail	46%	45%	43%	44%	44%	43%	45%	42%	41%	41%	42%
Non-profit Marketing Mail	50%	49%	51%	48%	50%	48%	50%	46%	45%	45%	48%
By sender industry											
Financial	38%	36%	34%	35%	35%	36%	37%	35%	35%	38%	38%
Merchant	55%	57%	56%	57%	58%	57%	57%	58%	56%	55%	56%
Service	43%	42%	41%	42%	41%	40%	40%	36%	38%	38%	40%
Social	49%	49%	49%	46%	49%	47%	49%	44%	43%	41%	45%
By past relationship (Marketing Mail Advertising only)											
Existing customer	60%	59%	59%	59%	60%	60%	62%	60%	59%	58%	60%
Prospect	26%	25%	25%	25%	25%	25%	26%	23%	23%	24%	26%
Considering Responding											
All First-Class and Marketing Mail Advertising	13%	13%	13%	12%	12%	12%	11%	11%	10%	9%	9%
By ad type											
FCM Ad only	13%	12%	14%	12%	13%	11%	8%	8%	9%	11%	9%
FCM Ad enclosed	16%	17%	14%	15%	16%	16%	13%	14%	15%	13%	15%
Commercial Marketing Mail	12%	13%	12%	11%	11%	11%	11%	10%	9%	8%	8%
Non-profit Marketing Mail	15%	15%	15%	14%	15%	15%	14%	13%	13%	12%	13%
By sender industry											
Financial	6%	7%	6%	5%	6%	5%	6%	5%	5%	5%	5%
Merchant	18%	20%	20%	19%	18%	18%	18%	18%	17%	15%	15%
Service	10%	9%	9%	9%	8%	8%	8%	7%	7%	7%	6%
Social	15%	13%	14%	13%	13%	14%	13%	12%	11%	10%	11%
By past relationship (Marketing Mail Advertising only)											
Existing customer	19%	20%	19%	18%	18%	19%	19%	18%	17%	15%	15%
Prospect	3%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. Notes: Mail pieces for which reading or response treatment were not provided are excluded. Past relationship data was not collected for First-Class Mail prior to 2021.

Table A-15: First-Class Mail Received by Household Demographics

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
All Households	348.2	329.3	329.0	316.1	306.7	288.8	278.1	271.4	258.2	244.4	221.7
By Age Group											
Under 35	242.0	213.8	209.0	194.5	169.6	176.6	158.6	153.4	144.5	132.3	113.6
35-54	353.5	326.8	329.0	304.3	295.3	269.5	264.9	249.4	243.9	226.9	201.4
Over 55	398.7	389.1	384.1	381.0	375.0	351.3	337.8	337.6	318.0	303.9	282.7
DK/RF	356.5	377.1	340.9	295.8	361.4	332.0	303.9	318.7	305.2	363.8	244.5
By Income Group											
Less than $35,000	272.4	238.9	247.5	230.7	232.0	229.3	205.6	196.0	193.4	183.5	176.4
$35,000-$64,999	332.0	330.6	306.6	302.6	289.6	272.9	260.1	246.3	239.5	212.5	210.5
$65,000-$99,999	382.8	366.2	359.8	364.3	332.0	303.5	302.0	288.3	265.5	271.0	222.6
$100,000 or More	454.6	424.0	425.2	380.6	369.6	344.1	325.5	317.7	305.3	276.4	247.9
DK/RF	369.0	346.0	345.7	328.2	333.5	300.5	291.9	311.2	273.0	265.4	238.0
By Highest Level of Education											
Less than high school	309.9	310.5	321.2	331.8	276.9	264.0	271.1	316.6	294.2	221.1	235.1
High school graduate	333.4	324.0	332.7	321.8	325.1	296.7	284.9	272.5	251.6	260.8	231.8
Some college or technical school	341.3	319.9	324.7	301.5	293.5	290.7	267.8	257.1	244.8	245.6	226.0
College graduate	374.3	344.4	331.6	319.3	306.5	287.4	280.5	268.6	261.8	239.2	212.2
DK/RF	375.8	342.5	294.0	283.9	312.6	284.5	243.7	301.3	260.0	226.5	223.4
By Home Ownership											
Own	404.8	397.6	388.7	377.7	363.4	340.9	328.6	326.1	307.3	285.8	259.1
Rent	246.2	212.9	219.4	203.8	199.5	189.6	170.0	169.9	168.1	164.9	147.2
DK/RF	340.2	290.2	265.9	277.5	290.2	272.4	288.7	304.9	268.9	222.0	248.7

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A-16: First-Class Mail Sent by Household Demographics

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
All Households	80.3	77.2	68.0	62.3	57.5	52.2	50.9	50.3	43.9	33.4	26.6
By Age Group											
Under 35	40.4	46.2	29.5	23.3	24.0	15.9	16.5	12.2	15.3	15.0	4.5
35-54	68.5	70.4	51.2	43.8	41.0	36.0	29.9	33.7	26.3	18.0	16.9
Over 55	111.4	98.8	98.1	93.5	83.7	79.8	79.6	78.3	69.0	52.0	43.1
DK/RF	95.0	78.6	113.9	89.3	102.2	71.0	89.5	70.7	63.4	76.2	33.7
By Income Group											
Less than $35,000	61.7	53.0	55.8	46.9	43.0	40.0	45.1	39.0	32.1	20.6	23.4
$35,000-$64,999	80.0	80.1	63.5	63.1	63.0	53.0	42.7	51.8	51.4	35.5	25.7
$65,000-$99,999	82.9	82.3	68.0	67.3	60.7	47.5	53.3	49.8	44.4	35.1	26.8
$100,000 or More	108.5	104.8	77.0	69.5	65.2	60.7	54.2	52.3	42.4	33.7	25.5
DK/RF	85.3	80.7	82.6	68.6	58.5	63.2	60.4	60.2	50.0	42.1	31.8
By Highest Level of Education											
Less than high school	68.2	60.4	63.3	53.1	39.9	44.7	39.6	46.1	34.1	23.3	20.9
High school graduate	77.1	78.0	69.5	60.9	64.4	50.9	51.7	49.2	50.8	33.3	25.6
Some college or technical school	74.3	75.3	66.2	64.1	51.7	48.3	43.8	54.4	37.6	33.1	29.7
College graduate	90.2	82.5	69.4	64.3	59.3	56.9	55.5	50.0	44.6	35.5	26.9
DK/RF	71.3	80.7	53.6	66.9	45.4	39.2	51.5	43.7	51.4	20.6	12.2
By Home Ownership											
Own	98.7	95.2	80.8	75.2	73.4	66.1	62.7	63.2	57.1	40.5	32.7
Rent	46.9	47.2	42.6	38.6	28.7	26.2	25.2	26.7	18.7	17.6	14.2
DK/RF	89.1	45.4	88.9	57.0	22.8	35.7	62.4	50.0	63.8	59.6	35.7

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A–17: Commercial Marketing Mail Received by Household Demographics

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
All Households	479.7	472.7	479.3	456.3	439.6	420.3	346.6	358.9	357.5	319.8	282.3
By Age Group											
Under 35	322.7	317.3	316.6	305.3	281.8	266.9	218.9	205.2	213.7	160.6	165.8
35-54	476.4	470.4	475.9	452.3	418.9	404.6	318.4	334.3	339.1	306.1	260.4
Over 55	561.9	550.5	556.9	528.1	523.0	498.6	420.3	441.5	432.8	399.8	347.0
DK/RF	569.5	586.8	525.9	454.6	528.1	460.3	385.9	461.3	424.7	394.8	350.3
By Income Group											
Less than $35,000	312.0	307.0	319.9	295.7	282.7	292.8	229.4	231.4	230.1	178.3	174.4
$35,000-$64,999	457.5	445.9	436.8	417.3	418.2	372.9	323.5	321.8	337.2	282.6	263.5
$65,000-$99,999	557.7	542.8	528.9	513.8	486.3	443.5	353.0	367.5	350.8	335.1	273.9
$100,000 or More	729.5	696.8	701.1	634.0	576.8	556.2	445.0	464.8	456.3	426.7	359.0
DK/RF	490.5	491.9	489.9	467.8	466.8	453.0	369.8	396.2	384.9	336.5	296.2
By Highest Level of Education											
Less than high school	303.4	363.8	402.1	386.2	337.2	330.0	269.5	284.4	275.2	230.1	220.0
High school graduate	441.9	428.6	451.5	418.0	417.3	386.7	330.2	337.9	350.3	284.4	254.1
Some college or technical school	465.4	469.7	460.3	435.6	417.5	417.4	328.9	353.3	351.4	319.9	279.7
College graduate	568.2	538.0	528.8	507.8	482.4	460.9	375.8	387.0	378.6	356.2	308.7
DK/RF	508.7	553.3	417.0	412.3	485.2	384.4	325.3	406.9	382.5	272.4	267.8
By Home Ownership											
Own	581.9	581.6	570.2	546.2	527.9	503.1	412.3	435.2	426.2	390.7	341.4
Rent	296.1	287.7	310.5	291.0	270.3	265.9	210.0	218.9	232.3	188.6	170.2
DK/RF	459.4	403.7	412.4	425.1	454.1	332.3	318.8	367.5	350.4	213.6	240.5

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A-18: Non-Profit Marketing Mail Received by Household Demographics

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
All Households	101.2	100.7	90.7	93.3	92.9	92.2	89.4	94.6	91.4	85.5	75.1
By Age Group											
Under 35	37.6	44.8	30.4	28.4	27.5	27.7	25.3	24.7	29.9	23.4	22.6
35-54	69.8	78.8	66.4	71.5	66.8	63.5	56.9	58.1	52.5	55.5	48.7
Over 55	161.7	147.3	137.2	138.2	139.5	141.3	139.0	149.5	145.6	132.9	115.7
DK/RF	129.7	125.0	138.5	142.1	176.2	111.4	123.9	164.8	148.2	179.1	126.4
By Income Group											
Less than $35,000	70.2	66.5	57.1	58.3	53.1	62.7	55.2	54.0	56.4	49.4	50.1
$35,000-$64,999	81.9	98.9	79.7	87.6	89.0	86.5	87.8	89.5	83.5	94.2	71.1
$65,000-$99,999	109.2	113.7	100.4	102.8	106.6	90.9	88.8	102.0	84.8	85.3	65.9
$100,000 or More	167.3	137.0	132.7	128.3	123.6	115.9	105.8	111.1	119.5	103.9	91.7
DK/RF	112.9	110.8	102.3	101.2	100.8	112.9	113.1	120.5	106.9	95.4	89.5
By Highest Level of Education											
Less than high school	48.7	67.7	47.6	51.3	58.6	42.9	49.7	49.6	43.9	43.7	43.9
High school graduate	85.2	88.4	80.7	79.7	82.5	84.5	84.2	86.1	78.7	67.4	56.6
Some college or technical school	94.9	95.2	82.0	82.6	81.5	81.5	83.1	92.3	77.7	79.0	80.5
College graduate	132.3	122.7	112.5	116.7	111.5	112.7	101.7	109.1	113.3	104.6	87.3
DK/RF	110.4	97.9	86.6	64.6	99.1	61.3	55.4	98.0	108.0	118.4	81.2
By Home Ownership											
Own	130.2	134.1	116.3	119.2	120.1	116.4	111.6	124.3	118.0	110.9	96.0
Rent	49.3	44.0	42.5	46.3	41.8	46.4	42.1	40.6	43.3	36.9	34.4
DK/RF	87.4	72.5	85.5	69.7	75.9	79.9	100.6	90.8	81.8	66.4	69.3

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A–19: Periodical Mail Received by Household Demographics

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
All Households	43.3	40.0	39.9	39.4	35.0	32.4	29.6	27.6	25.0	25.7	19.9
By Age Group											
Under 35	23.5	21.8	20.0	15.7	14.8	12.2	8.8	10.0	7.5	8.2	4.6
35-54	36.6	34.4	33.5	31.2	27.6	23.5	20.0	18.4	18.5	14.9	11.6
Over 55	59.9	54.0	54.1	56.3	49.3	47.9	45.2	41.5	37.3	40.0	32.5
DK/RF	37.3	48.4	45.6	44.5	44.8	35.6	33.4	39.7	36.1	84.7	24.7
By Income Group											
Less than $35,000	29.9	22.0	26.9	28.2	21.8	21.4	20.6	18.0	13.8	17.5	13.1
$35,000-$64,999	39.6	37.5	36.1	37.8	31.6	30.7	26.3	24.9	26.2	23.4	19.2
$65,000-$99,999	46.4	49.5	46.1	41.0	37.4	32.6	34.8	27.3	24.1	23.8	22.9
$100,000 or More	68.7	62.1	55.7	51.5	46.6	39.9	33.7	32.5	31.3	31.9	21.6
DK/RF	45.6	41.2	41.3	41.8	41.6	40.2	32.2	35.9	27.5	29.9	21.4
By Highest Level of Education											
Less than high school	21.9	29.0	27.7	46.0	18.3	17.5	15.1	17.2	23.7	19.6	7.8
High school graduate	41.1	35.3	37.8	36.7	36.1	30.5	30.8	27.2	24.4	26.3	19.2
Some college or technical school	36.8	35.3	36.7	36.6	32.7	30.1	26.1	24.6	22.1	23.7	20.5
College graduate	55.5	49.9	46.3	42.2	38.5	37.7	32.6	31.2	26.8	26.7	21.9
DK/RF	39.4	26.4	24.6	30.9	32.2	29.4	20.2	25.2	31.7	31.7	12.2
By Home Ownership											
Own	53.9	52.6	48.7	49.2	44.0	40.5	36.7	35.4	33.4	32.9	26.2
Rent	24.1	18.8	24.2	21.7	17.7	17.4	14.9	13.7	9.0	10.3	8.2
DK/RF	47.8	27.8	25.7	30.6	34.7	22.9	21.9	20.2	36.6	38.4	12.2

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A-20: Packages Received by Household Demographics

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
All Households	25.2	29.5	32.9	35.8	38.6	35.7	44.7	48.5	51.0	48.7	48.5
By Age Group											
Under 35	26.2	25.7	34.5	32.6	37.0	34.9	43.6	42.5	42.2	44.7	40.1
35-54	25.4	32.6	37.3	38.8	42.9	38.4	49.7	58.5	60.6	54.7	55.1
Over 55	24.5	28.4	29.1	34.7	35.8	34.0	41.7	44.2	48.4	46.0	47.0
DK/RF	22.3	41.0	23.1	42.4	44.3	44.7	45.3	37.9	34.2	49.8	55.6
By Income Group											
Less than $35,000	17.6	18.0	19.2	21.0	19.5	21.0	27.4	32.2	37.5	39.0	29.4
$35,000-$64,999	24.1	26.0	32.4	31.1	35.6	35.9	40.8	43.0	44.3	46.6	45.4
$65,000-$99,999	29.5	36.9	42.5	39.1	44.4	38.0	46.9	54.2	52.5	42.5	47.1
$100,000 or More	38.8	47.1	47.4	56.2	54.7	48.5	57.5	64.7	68.7	60.1	62.6
DK/RF	23.0	27.6	27.6	35.8	42.7	36.4	48.7	45.4	45.9	53.1	47.8
By Highest Level of Education											
Less than high school	14.2	24.4	23.1	34.7	24.3	20.6	43.4	37.0	44.3	66.6	32.6
High school graduate	21.3	22.2	25.2	30.8	29.6	33.0	37.7	46.1	44.5	45.3	46.5
Some college or technical school	25.8	29.3	34.3	32.0	38.9	36.5	43.5	43.6	52.5	43.7	47.5
College graduate	31.1	36.7	40.0	41.7	46.4	39.4	50.0	54.9	55.6	50.5	52.0
DK/RF	19.3	28.7	21.1	29.6	56.1	43.8	51.0	34.9	41.3	21.5	55.2
By Home Ownership											
Own	27.6	34.1	35.1	40.8	42.5	40.3	47.8	53.9	57.4	49.6	54.9
Rent	20.7	21.7	29.0	26.1	31.4	26.9	37.9	38.9	39.9	47.0	37.2
DK/RF	25.7	28.2	29.6	39.1	34.1	37.7	49.6	45.3	41.4	37.6	28.9

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A-21: Packages Sent by Household Demographics

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
All Households	5.2	4.8	3.9	3.4	3.9	3.4	5.4	4.9	5.8	4.4	4.6
By Age Group											
Under 35	4.6	6.7	3.8	3.7	3.6	3.3	3.5	4.0	3.6	3.8	4.0
35-54	4.6	4.6	4.4	4.2	3.9	3.7	7.1	5.4	7.5	4.8	5.3
Over 55	5.9	4.0	3.5	2.7	4.0	3.3	4.9	4.9	5.7	3.5	4.4
DK/RF	4.3	4.1	3.6	3.6	6.2	3.6	5.8	3.0	2.6	35.1	3.1
By Income Group											
Less than $35,000	3.1	3.3	3.9	2.6	2.0	2.4	4.0	2.8	4.4	5.9	1.8
$35,000-$64,999	8.4	5.0	3.7	3.4	3.7	3.1	4.6	3.7	4.7	2.7	2.7
$65,000-$99,999	5.0	7.0	4.4	3.4	5.1	4.0	5.9	6.6	6.8	3.1	6.0
$100,000 or More	5.1	4.5	4.2	4.3	5.3	4.4	6.4	6.2	7.9	3.8	6.6
DK/RF	3.8	5.2	3.2	3.6	4.0	3.4	5.6	4.7	4.6	7.1	4.9
By Highest Level of Education											
Less than high school	13.5	3.2	3.4	1.0	1.5	0.6	6.2	1.3	5.4	5.1	3.0
High school graduate	2.8	2.8	2.4	2.4	3.4	4.3	4.9	3.7	4.4	2.8	3.8
Some college or technical school	3.5	5.2	4.5	3.2	3.1	2.9	5.1	4.7	6.7	5.7	4.8
College graduate	5.5	6.5	4.7	4.7	5.0	3.7	5.8	6.4	6.4	4.5	5.3
DK/RF	3.6	4.8	2.2	3.2	5.5	2.3	3.2	2.6	2.5	6.0	2.8
By Home Ownership											
Own	4.4	4.8	4.5	3.5	4.6	4.1	5.5	5.2	5.6	3.6	5.1
Rent	6.5	4.8	2.7	3.3	2.5	2.3	5.2	4.3	6.4	4.5	3.7
DK/RF	3.1	2.7	4.2	2.3	4.0	1.4	4.2	4.4	2.7	23.8	4.4

Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024.

Table A-22: Mail Received and Sent by Sampling Stratum

(Pieces per Household per Year)

	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
First-Class Mail Received and Sent*											
30 Largest MSAs	405.5	401.0	383.9	362.9	344.9	313.7	306.0	308.5	283.4	270.0	235.2
Other MSAs	393.4	359.3	363.1	353.1	338.2	328.6	304.3	295.7	279.1	264.3	236.8
Non-Metro Counties	427.4	369.7	375.3	352.7	355.5	333.0	339.2	292.0	297.6	259.4	244.2
Marketing Mail Received											
30 Largest MSAs	630.1	661.4	634.9	605.9	574.7	538.9	461.4	480.5	500.3	476.4	396.9
Other MSAs	544.8	507.5	518.9	512.5	506.1	498.6	422.7	448.2	424.0	361.8	338.4
Non-Metro Counties	512.1	455.5	490.3	455.6	457.2	454.6	381.3	359.8	362.3	311.1	289.8
Periodicals Mail Received											
30 Largest MSAs	41.3	40.3	40.7	36.9	35.9	29.0	28.7	24.5	21.4	25.4	17.5
Other MSAs	42.9	37.1	35.6	37.4	31.8	32.8	27.0	27.2	24.8	21.7	18.7
Non-Metro Counties	53.6	49.9	52.4	56.9	43.3	45.5	43.0	41.5	37.3	38.3	31.0
Packages Received and Sent*											
30 Largest MSAs	30.2	35.5	38.2	39.3	40.5	35.3	45.7	45.9	51.8	50.8	43.7
Other MSAs	28.2	30.5	34.2	38.6	42.9	39.5	50.5	57.1	56.4	48.0	55.2
Non-Metro Counties	20.8	25.8	27.2	29.5	35.3	41.1	47.4	54.8	61.4	63.2	67.1

*Source: HDS Diary Samples FY 2014 to FY 2024. *Double-counting removed from First-Class Mail and Packages Mail to account for household to household mail.*

Appendix B: Methodology

Study Design and Methodology

The U.S. Postal Service Household Diary Study (HDS), conducted by NuStats on behalf of the U.S. Postal Service, is a continuously fielded study that measures household mail volumes, mail usage, and attitudes about the mail and advertising. The HDS uses a two-stage survey design: Stage 1 is a household recruitment survey conducted online or by phone with an interviewer. Stage 2 is a self-completed diary of mail sent and received that can be completed on paper or online. The HDS uses a multi-mode approach to minimize response bias, to improve data accuracy through efficient data checking and household re-contacts, and to provide immediate telephone assistance to participants during their diary week.

Household Recruitment Survey
The **household recruitment survey** collects information on household demographics, recall of bill payments and bill & statement presentments by mail vs. other methods, adoption and use of communications technologies, and attitudes towards advertising.
Diary
The **diary** covers a seven-day period (Monday to Sunday) and collects information about each mail piece or package received and sent by the household during that time, such as the industry of the sender, the purpose, and, for advertising pieces, the household's treatment of the mail.

Sampling Design

This section describes the household selection process for participation in the HDS. A sample is the representative subset of the survey population used to gain information about the entire population. The population of inference for the HDS is all U.S. households. The sampling design ensures each household has an equal chance of selection.

The sampling design allows projections of results to all U.S. households. The Postal Service provides an address sample that NuStats matches for known telephone listings. Invitation letters are mailed to all sampled households with information about how to participate, allowing them to complete the recruitment survey online or by phone according to their preference. Diaries and/or instructional materials are then mailed to eligible households and completed by each household unit either on paper, or online.

A master national sample is specified and drawn by in-house sampling statisticians. The Postal Service draws the household probability sample from the national address database following NuStats specifications. The master list, sorted by ZIP code, is used to draw a systematic stratified sample, which was then tagged with variables indicating each housing unit's geographic location in terms of Census region and urban/rural location.

The sampling design involves stratification by urban/rural location and Census regions, ensuring even coverage across the United States. The sample was drawn for each of the four quarters based on known proportions of households within a Census region and urban or rural location. Census regions are defined by state. Urban and rural location is defined by county and metropolitan status as defined by the U.S. Census Bureau. The urban and rural location strata are defined by county as follows:

- **Stratum 1**: Counties that are part of the 30 largest metropolitan areas in the United States, as defined by the 2020 US Census.
- **Stratum 2:** Counties that are part of metropolitan areas but are not in Stratum 1.
- **Stratum 3**: Counties that are not part of a metropolitan area.

Quarterly sample frames were then derived based on the amount of sample needed for each quarter, and sample was allocated to region and strata cells based on known proportions as indicated by Census 2020 count of households.

The sample was continuously "fielded" throughout all 52 weeks of the year. Sample was released in a manner designed to recruit equal sample sizes for each diary week. This year saw 5,475 completes vs. the target of 5,200 households. Table B.1 shows the distribution of recruited households and diary-completing households.

Table B.1: Sample by Postal Quarter

Quarter	Required Sample	Recruited Households	Diary-Completing Households
Quarter 1	1,300	2,538	1,306
Quarter 2	1,300	2,450	1,478
Quarter 3	1,300	2,402	1,403
Quarter 4	1,300	2,396	1,288
Total	5,200	9,786	5,475

Data Collection Method

The study uses a two-stage design in which households are recruited to participate in the diary study by choosing to use a telephone interview or an online survey (Stage 1) and recruited households complete a seven-day diary of mail received and sent (Stage 2) either by paper or online.

Stage 1: Household Recruitment Interview

The main function of the household recruitment interview is to recruit households to participate in the diary study. In addition, the interview collects information on household and person demographics, recall of mail sent and received, adoption and use of communication technologies, bill payment behavior, and attitudes towards advertising.

Households completed the recruitment interview via computer-assisted telephone interviewing (CATI) technology or by using an online survey. The FY 2024 household interview consisted of 9,511 online surveys and 275 phone interviews completed with an adult member (age 18 or older) in the household. Table B.2 below shows the distribution of recruited households by recruitment type.

Table B.2: Sample by Recruitment Type

Recruitment Interview	Completed	Sample Percent
Phone	275	2.8%
Web	9,511	97.2%
Total	9,786	100%

These respondents represented a cross-section of U.S. households by geography. The household interview contained 116 data items and took an average of 23.85 minutes to administer. The flow of the interview included the following elements:

- **Introduction.** Each interview began with an introduction and purpose of the interview. The interviewer also verified the respondent's address.
- **Use of postal services**. The use of post offices and private mailing services in general and for mailing packages was explored.
- **Technology adoption and use**. Questions were asked about use of the internet and related activities, such as use of online invitation services and online shopping.
- **Payment and presentment recall**. The respondent was asked to recall how many bills and statements were received, and how many bills were paid by the household by mail and by other methods over the previous month.
- **Periodicals**. Respondents were asked how many magazine and newspaper subscriptions their household has in print and online.
- **Advertising**. Attitudes about advertising received by mail vs. by other methods were elicited.
- **Coupon use**. Respondents were asked how many coupons the household used in the previous month, separately for coupons received by mail and by other methods.
- **Household and person demographics**. Demographic items included gender, age, marital status, employment status, educational attainment, race/ethnicity, household income, home ownership, residence tenure, and dwelling type.

The completion rate for the FY 2024 study (defined as the proportion of respondents who completed the diary portion relative to all recruited respondents) was 55.9%, compared to 49.3% in FY 2023. Most recruitment refusals took place prior to hearing who NuStats was and why the firm was calling. Refusal households that were later re-contacted cited time constraints and privacy concerns as reasons for not participating.

Stage 2: Mail Diary Package

Recruited households are mailed the address of the website for the online diary, instructions, and a toll-free "help" telephone number. If they choose to complete the diary on paper, they are sent seven mail diaries.

The diary package contains a Certificate of Appreciation, Instruction Booklet, and a photo-based "Quick Start" sheet. The Instruction Booklet provided information about the study, answers to frequently asked

questions, instructions for filling out the diary, guidelines for sorting mail, and examples of mail markings. The paper diary instrument was composed of two parts:

- **The Question sheets**. The Question sheets are color-coded by mail classification (First-Class Mail received, First-Class Mail sent, Marketing Mail, Nonprofit, etc.). Information collected about each mail classification included: type of mail piece (i.e., envelope, postcard, catalog, etc.), mail classification, mail type, sender type, information about advertising enclosed, and receiver reaction or responses to the mail piece.
- **Seven answer booklets,** each specific to a day of the week. Each booklet was arranged by mail classification and color-coded to correspond to the question sheets.

The online diary guides respondents through the questions and records the information they provide about each day's mail. Respondents participating by mail are instructed to enclose pertinent information from the envelopes of each mail piece received to enable NuStats editors to verify or clarify quantity and classes of mail recorded in the diaries. Respondents participating online are instructed to upload photographs of the envelopes. NuStats uses a three-stage editing process to check the accuracy of information recorded on paper diaries. First, returned diary packages are culled for those that represent a reasonable attempt to complete the diary. Second, the diary information recorded for each day is checked to ensure that answers were complete and logical, as well as to verify recorded information against the mail markings returned in the package. The diaries are then scanned using Optical Character Recognition (OCR) software. In stage three, a verifier re-checks the diary information recorded in the OCR software for each day. This second edit functions as a quality control check to ensure data accuracy.

Overall, about 1% of returned diaries did not pass the edit checking process.

Of the 9,786 households recruited to receive a diary package, 5,475 returned acceptable completed diaries (defined as containing data suitable for analysis) to NuStats, for a completion rate of 55.9%.

Data Management

Data management entails processing the information resulting from the recruitment surveys and diaries, making it available for analysis, storing it, and documenting it. Recruitment surveys were conducted using both web and CATI technology. Questionnaire and relevant data checks were programmed into a master questionnaire that was used in the web and phone survey. Recorded data was extracted from the web and CATI software into a database management file.

Diary information was recorded through the web and on paper. Returned paper diary information was recorded (entered) through optical scanning technology. The diary data, once scanned using Teleform software, was captured in a database management file. Similarly, web diary information was stored in a web server and later captured in a database management file.

After completion of data collection, editing and entry tasks, the survey data are stored in nine data files. One data file contains the recruitment data and another eight contain diary data—one file for each mail classification (First-Class Mail received, First-Class Mail sent, etc.). These files were all developed in SAS-PC.

The file variables are identified by variable name. For each file variable, the File Information contains:

- Label, which is a brief description of the variable.
- Measurement level, which specifies the level of measurement as scale (numeric data on an interval or ratio scale), ordinal, or nominal. Nominal and ordinal data can be either string (alphanumeric) or numeric.
- Value formats, which identify the response codes.
- Column width and alignment.

Several SAS programming operations were necessary to put the Mail Diary data in the desired form for analysis. The structure for these programs is contained in a separate File Information document that accompanied the data delivery.

Various editing routines are used to check the consistency of the reported data and to identify reporting or entry errors. Routine edit checks are conducted to examine questionnaire responses for reasonableness and consistency across items. Routine checks include such items as:

- Response code range checks.
- Checks for proper data skips and patterns of answering questions consistent with prior answers.
- Checks for realistic responses (e.g., number of online purchases possible in one month).
- Checks for high frequency of item non-response (missing data from question refusals).

When conducting these checks, data are compared against the actual survey forms. NuStats identifies extreme values that are impossible or unlikely and corrects inconsistent data when possible.

Some extreme/inconsistent data values unable to be corrected or verified are edited to missing values.

In addition, NuStats performs in-depth customized data checks to ensure data within each record of the Household Interview are logically consistent. For example, a respondent should have reported paying bills online only if he/she also reported having Internet access.

Raw variables, derived variables, and analytical programs are documented in a data documentation binder that accompanies the data delivery. Any information that could be directly or indirectly used to identify individual respondents, such as respondent names, addresses, or telephone numbers, is removed to protect respondent confidentiality and privacy. Such information is stored in a locked archival file.

Sample Demographic Profile (All Counts Unweighted), Government Fiscal Year 2024

Table B.3: Annual Household Income by Recruitment/Retrieval Status

Annual Household Income	Recruited Households		Total	Sample Percent	Population Percent
	Completed Diary	Did not Complete Diary			
$0 – $24,999	301	418	719	5.5%	14.1%
$25,000 – $34,999	357	383	740	6.5%	6.9%
$35,000 – $49,999	478	415	893	8.7%	10.3%
$50,000 – $64,999	462	360	822	8.4%	10.1%
$65,000 – $79,999	499	373	872	9.1%	8.2%
$80,000 – $99,999	559	386	945	10.2%	9.5%
$100,000 or more	1,886	1,205	3,091	34.4%	40.8%
Don't Know	116	136	252	2.1%	N/A
Refused	817	635	1,452	14.9%	N/A
Total	5,475	4,311	9,786	100.0%	100.0%

Notes: Sample Percent based only on retrieved households that provided a response to the Household Income question. Population percent based on U.S. Census Bureau, Current Population Survey Annual Demographic File (March 2024).

Table B.4: Number of Adults in Household by Recruitment/Retrieval Status

Number of Adults in Household	Recruited Households		Total	Sample Percent	Population Percent
	Completed Diary	Did not Complete Diary			
One	1,472	1,274	2,746	26.9%	33.2%
Two	2,278	1,466	3,744	41.6%	50.1%
Three	764	660	1,424	14.0%	11.3%
Four	582	511	1,093	10.6%	4.1%
Five or More	379	400	779	6.9%	1.3%
Total	5,475	4,311	9,786	100.0%	100.0%

Notes: Sample Percent based only on retrieved households. Population percent based on U.S. Census Bureau, Current Population Survey Annual Demographic File (March 2024).

Table B.5: Geographic Region by Recruitment/Retrieval Status

Geographic Region	Recruited Households		Total	Sample Percent	Population Percent
	Completed Diary	Did not Complete Diary			
Northeast	968	756	1,724	17.7%	17.6%
Midwest	1,205	820	2,025	22.0%	21.7%
South	1,938	1,689	3,627	35.4%	38.3%
West	1,364	1,046	2,410	24.9%	22.3%
Total	5,475	4,311	9,786	100.0%	100.0%

Notes: Sample Percent based only on retrieved households. Population percent based on 2020 Decennial Census P.L. 94-171 Redistricting Data Summary Files.

Table B.6: Urban/Rural Location by Recruitment/Retrieval Status

Urban/Rural Location	Recruited Households		Total	Sample Percent	Population Percent
	Completed Diary	Did not Complete Diary			
30 Largest Metro Areas	2,435	2,018	4,453	44.5%	44.3%
Other Metro Areas	2,336	1,739	4,075	42.7%	41.4%
Non-Metropolitan Areas	704	554	1,258	12.9%	14.3%
Total	5,475	4,311	9,786	100.0%	100.0%

Notes: Sample Percent based only on retrieved households. Population percent based on 2020 Decennial Census P.L. 94-171 Redistricting Data Summary Files.

Table B.7: Age of Head of Household by Recruitment/Retrieval Status

Age of Head of Household	Recruited Households		Total	Sample Percent	Population Percent
	Completed Diary	Did not Complete Diary			
18 - 24	78	146	224	1.4%	4.3%
25 - 44	1,449	1,376	2,825	26.5%	33.3%
45 - 64	1,919	1,448	3,367	35.1%	33.9%
65+	1,944	1,252	3,196	35.5%	28.5%
Refused	85	89	174	1.6%	N/A
Total	5,475	4,311	9,786	100.0%	100.0%

Notes: Sample Percent based only on retrieved households that provided a valid response. Population percent based on U.S. Census Bureau, Current Population Survey Annual Demographic File (March 2024).

Table B.8: Educational Attainment of Head of Household by Recruitment/Retrieval Status

Educational Attainment of Head of Household	Recruited Households		Total	Sample Percent	Population Percent
	Completed Diary	Did not Complete Diary			
8th grade or less	31	53	84	0.6%	2.8%
Some high school	86	135	221	1.6%	4.8%
High school graduate	664	675	1,339	12.1%	25.7%
Some college	955	922	1,877	17.4%	15.8%
Technical school graduate	388	327	715	7.1%	4.9%
College graduate	1,825	1,289	3,114	33.3%	30.6%
Postgraduate work	1,425	775	2,200	26.0%	15.4%
Refused	101	135	236	1.8%	N/A
Total	5,475	4,311	9,786	100.0%	100.0%

Notes: Sample Percent based only on retrieved households that provided a valid response. Population percent based on U.S. Census Bureau, Current Population Survey Annual Demographic File (March 2024).

Data Weighting and Expansion

This section explains the methodology used for creating sampling and expansion weights for the FY 2024 Household Diary Study.

The FY 2024 HDS uses both weighting and expansion factors to 1) adjust the sample data to match population parameters and 2) expand mail volumes exhibited in the diary sample to all U.S. households.

Weighting Criteria

Sampling weights are produced separately for the households that participated in the recruitment phase of the FY 2024 HDS, and the narrower group that completed and returned a diary. There are four main weighting variables: Geography, Education, Age, and Homeownership. The geography variable is a single variable capturing a household's Census region and urban/rural location:

Urban/rural strata: As mentioned previously, there are three urban/rural strata. A household was classified as residing in the top 30 metropolitan areas nationwide, any other metropolitan area, or a non-metropolitan area.[1] Table B.9 provides unweighted sample counts from FY 2024 recruitment data for urban/rural strata:

1 Core-Based Statistical Area (CBSA) is defined within the sample according to the official definition used by the U.S. Census Bureau. CBSAs refer collectively to both metropolitan and micropolitan statistical areas. Non-metropolitan areas are counties that do not belong to a metropolitan area. Each sample county was assigned to a stratum according to its metropolitan status.

Table B.9: HDS 2024 Recruitment Data: Urban/Rural Location

Urban/ Rural Location	Household	Percent	Cumulative Percent
30 Largest Metro Areas	4,453	45.5%	45.5%
Other Metro Areas	4,075	41.6%	87.1%
Non-Metro Counties	1,258	12.9%	100.0%
Total	9,786	100.0%	

Four Census Regions:
Northeast: Connecticut, Maine, Massachusetts, New Hampshire, New Jersey, New York, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, and Vermont.
Midwest: Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Kansas, Michigan, Minnesota, Missouri, Nebraska, North Dakota, Ohio, South Dakota, and Wisconsin.
South: Alabama, Arkansas, Delaware, District of Columbia, Florida, Georgia, Kentucky, Louisiana, Maryland, Mississippi, North Carolina, Oklahoma, South Carolina, Tennessee, Texas, Virginia, and West Virginia.
West: Arizona, Alaska, California, Colorado, Hawaii, Idaho, Montana, Nevada, New Mexico, Oregon, Utah, Washington, and Wyoming.

Regions: Table B.10 provides unweighted sample counts from FY 2024 recruitment data for region. Households were classified by state. There are four mutually exclusive regions as defined by the U.S. Census Bureau (along with respective states):

Table B.10: HDS 2024 Recruitment Data: Geographic Region

Geographic Region	Households	Percent	Cumulative Percent
Northeast	1,724	17.6%	17.6%
Midwest	2,025	20.7%	38.3%
South	3,627	37.1%	75.4%
West	2,410	24.6%	100.0%
Total	9,786	100.0%	

Urban/Rural Strata and Regions: Table B.11 shows the distribution of households from the FY 2024 recruitment sample by urban/rural strata and region.

Table B.11: Distribution of Households within Strata and Region

Geographic Region	Stratum *(Urban/Rural Location)*			Total
	30 Largest Metro Areas	Other Metro Areas	Non-Metro Areas	
Northeast	1,009	592	123	**1,724**
Midwest	638	972	415	**2,025**
South	1,484	1,653	490	**3,627**
West	1,322	858	230	**2,410**
Total	4,453	4,075	1,258	9,786

Population parameters for the intersection of the three urban/rural strata and four regions are based on 2020 Census counts of households by county. As Table B.12 shows, each county was grouped according to its location within these 12 mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive geographic categories.

The distribution of households across the 12 geographies according to the Census was used as one of the criteria in generating demographic weights. While the weights are calculated simultaneously to meet multiple criteria, a good rule of thumb is that the average weight on households in a given geography will be equal to the percentage of all households in that geography according to the Census divided by percentage of sampled households in that geography. These average weights appear in the last column to the right in Table B.12, though due to trimming, which will be discussed in the weighting procedures section, final weights in many years of analysis will not exactly match these averages.

Table B.12: HDS 2024 Recruitment Data: Construction of Geographic Weight

Stratum	Geographic Region	Households *(Population)*	Percent	Households *(Sample)*	Percent	Average Untrimmed Weight
30 Largest Metro Areas	Northeast	13,029,065	9.85%	1,009	10.3%	0.96
	Midwest	9,103,655	6.89%	638	6.5%	1.06
	South	19,699,633	14.90%	1,484	15.2%	0.98
	West	16,727,347	12.65%	1,322	13.5%	0.94
Other Metro Areas	Northeast	8,349,159	6.31%	592	6.0%	1.04
	Midwest	13,343,573	10.09%	972	9.9%	1.02
	South	23,117,235	17.48%	1,653	16.9%	1.04
	West	9,983,010	7.55%	858	8.8%	0.86
Non-Metro Areas	Northeast	1,945,132	1.47%	123	1.3%	1.17
	Midwest	6,290,364	4.76%	415	4.2%	1.12
	South	7,865,708	5.95%	490	5.0%	1.19
	West	2,761,715	2.09%	230	2.4%	0.89
Totals		132,215,596	100.0%	9,786	100.0%	1.00

Source: Household Population Estimates based on U.S. Census Bureau, 2024 Census.

Education: In addition to weighting for differences in geography between the sample and the population, the educational attainment of the head of household is used as a criterion in weighting. For those households in which either more than one person is identified as the head of household or no individual is identified as the head of household, one person is chosen based on the following sequence of criteria: 1) oldest male or 2) oldest female (if no male exists). For cases in which two candidates for the head of the household are of the same age, the respondent on the phone is chosen.

Known population parameters are based on weighted proportions derived from the U.S. Census Bureau's Current Population Survey annual demographic file for March 2024. For cases in which the head of household refuses to provide his/her education level, an educational level is imputed based on the average educational level of like cases. There were 236 such cases in 2024; mean levels of educational attainment were based on geography (strata and regions), as well as age and income level, if provided.

Table B.13: HDS 2024 Recruitment Data: Construction of Educational Attainment Weight

Educational Attainment	Households *(Population)*	Percent	Households *(Sample)*	Percent	Average Untrimmed Weight
Less than high school diploma	9,526,097	7.2%	305	3.1%	2.31
High school graduate	33,699,913	25.5%	1,339	13.7%	1.86
Some college	21,105,057	16.0%	1,888	19.3%	0.83
Technical school graduate	6,521,690	4.9%	893	9.1%	0.54
College graduate	40,767,376	30.8%	3,161	32.3%	0.95
Postgraduate work	20,595,464	15.6%	2,200	22.5%	0.69
Totals	132,215,596	100.0%	9,786	100.0%	1.00

Note: Education responses include imputed Don't Know/Refused answers.

Age: Age of the head of household is also used as a criterion for weighting. Known population parameters are based on weighted proportions derived from the U.S. Census Bureau's Current Population Survey annual demographic file for March 2024. For cases in which the head of household refuses to provide his/her age, an age level is imputed based on the average age level of like cases. There were 174 such cases in 2024; mean levels of age were based on geography (strata and regions), as well as education level, if provided.

Table B.14: HDS 2024 Recruitment Data: Construction of Age Weight

Age	Households *(Population)*	Percent	Households *(Sample)*	Percent	Average Untrimmed Weight
18-24	5,328,120	4.0%	224	2.3%	1.76
25-34	20,925,157	15.8%	1,135	11.6%	1.36
35-44	23,082,572	17.5%	1,694	17.3%	1.01
45-54	21,732,180	16.4%	1,663	17.0%	0.97
55-64	23,220,938	17.6%	1,860	19.0%	0.92
65-74	21,912,496	16.6%	1,969	20.1%	0.82
75+	16,014,134	12.1%	1,241	12.7%	0.96
Total	132,215,596	100.0%	9,786	100.0%	1.00

Note: Age responses include imputed Don't Know/Refused answers.

Homeownership: In addition to weighing for differences in income, education and geography between the sample and the population, homeownership status is used as a criterion for weighting. For those households in which homeownership is unknown, a status is imputed based on the average income level and geography of like cases. There were 313 such cases in 2024; mean levels of homeownership were based on geography (urban/rural strata and regions). Known population parameters are based on weighted proportions derived from the U.S. Census Bureau's Current Population Survey Quarterly Housing Vacancies and Homeownership file for November 2024. The average Homeownership rate in 2024 was 65.6%.

Weighting Procedures

As mentioned above, 9,786 households participated in the recruitment phase of the FY 2024 HDS, and 5,475 households completed usable diaries. Balancing weights were established as base weights by dividing the average number of diary households per week by the total number of diary households in a given week. This preliminary adjustment is carried out so that after the weighting process is complete, the weighted sample will be closer to having an equal number of households per week than otherwise.

The sample weighted using the above-mentioned base weights is then further weighted using a raking function in R, an iterative weighting procedure that adjusts survey weights so that marginal distributions of key demographic variables align with known population control totals. This ensures that the survey sample better represents the target population with respect to each of the criteria discussed above while preserving the overall sample size.

Starting in 2016 (with an interruption from 20221Q1 to 2023Q3 for diary weights—see below), post-raking weights have been trimmed such that no weight is larger than 5 or smaller than 0.2. The net value trimmed from the weights is distributed equally among the untrimmed weights. The purpose of trimming is to reduce the variance of estimates by reducing the likelihood that individual households with very large weights will skew the results. The cost of trimming is that the sample demographics will no longer exactly match the population demographics after trimming, though they will still be much closer than if there had been no weighting at all.

For generating aggregate annual volumes, a final adjustment in the form of expansion factors is made to expand the sample to the level of total households in the United States at the time of data collection, which was 132.2 million. The number of households in the United States is divided by the number of households that participated in the diary portion of the survey. The resultant factor is applied to each household in the survey. The expansion factor is multiplied by the sampling weight and then multiplied by 52 (the number of calendar weeks in one year) to derive nationwide annual volume estimates from the sample data.

Expansion Factor, 2024
132215596.33/ 5,475 = 24149

Special Weights

Two sampling issues have led to the use of special weights as a corrective measure over the history of the study.

In Fiscal 2020Q1, namely October through December 2019, the same sample was skewed such that too few households completed diaries in December, and these households had overwhelmingly young household heads. When standard weights are used to estimate volume, estimates for holiday cards are implausibly low, since they are overwhelmingly sent in December, which was under sampled and senders and recipients are older than average, while the sample skewed younger. Accordingly, special weights were generated for 2020Q1 which are independently raked to match Census demographics separately December and for October-November. These specially raked weights are then adjusted post-raking (and post-trimming) such that an equal number of weighted households represent each week of the quarter.

From Fiscal 2021Q1 until 2023Q3, an issue with the initial sample draw led to underrepresentation of households in multi-unit dwellings. Two changes are made to weights during this period to mitigate that issue. First, the share of households in multi-unit dwellings is included along with age, education, homeownership, and geography as a criterion for weighting, with households being considered multi-unit dwellers if their address includes a unit number. The target for the share of multi-unit dwelling households is the weighted share from 2020, rather than the actual share in the population, to maintain comparability of estimates over time. Second, weights calculated for this time period are left untrimmed, as, due to the lopsided sample, larger weights than usual are needed to match the desired demographic shares.

Data Presentation

Most volume data in this report is presented in pieces per household per year, with some data from the recruitment survey, such as bill payments and online purchases, presented as averages per household per month. Due to seasonality, and also to avoid bias due to some quarters having larger samples than others, pieces per household per year (as well as the per-month recruitment-based volumes) are calculated separately for each quarter—using weights generated as described above for each quarter's set of households—and then, for each year, pieces per household per year are calculated as a straight average of the four quarterly values.

Shares of volumes, such as the mail share of bill payments or mail share of bill & statement presentments, are calculated as the shares of the annual volumes calculated as described above.

Shares of households, such as the share of households giving citing a certain reason for paying bills by mail, are calculated on a quarterly basis, which the annual share being a straight average of four quarterly shares.